THE HOLLOWING

When the Beast of Bray Road resurfaces during Elkhorn's cryptid festival, four Ho-Chunk teens and a Ho-Chunk Nation detective uncover the decades-old development cover-up that created it—and must expose the truth before the face-stealing presence claims another generation.

Written by

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Based on, The Beast of Bray Road

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EXT. RURAL TRAILER - ELKHORN WISCONSIN - NIGHT - 2015

Razor-sharp wind slices through dark pines. A weathered trailer hunches at the forest's edge, a single window glowing with fragile candlelight. A lone heartbeat in the wilderness.

INT. TRAILER - NIGHT

Cramped interior breathes with history. Leather-bound books, carved wooden keepsakes crowd shelves — but so do chipped mugs. A tribal newsletter buried under a stack of mail spread out of a small table, as a tea kettle hums quietly in the tiny kitchen.

A small flat screen TV - muted - playing a college football game flickers in the corner.

KAI BLACKDEER (7), Ho-Chunk, huddles in a thick blanket, sketchbook pressed against his knees. His gaze never leaves his grandfather.

LUTHER BLACKDEER (70s), Ho-Chunk elder, carves a wood stick with surgical precision. His hands know the shape before the blade touches — weathered fingers moving with muscle memory. His eyes drift somewhere between present and memory.

KAI
Grandpa, is it true there’s something in that hollow?

Luther doesn’t look up.

LUTHER
Some places exist outside time. You feel them before seeing them. When your hair lifts and your chest tightens... that’s not fear. That’s this place remembering what happened here — and your body hearing it.

KAI
Is it the beast?

LUTHER
(chuckles, dry)
That’s what the town calls it. Puts it on T-shirts. Parades it through the street.

He gets up from his chair, a hissing tea kettle in the background. He pours hot water into two small Minnesota Viking mugs on the stove.

LUTHER (CONT'D)
But names aren't always protection.
Sometimes... they're invitations.

Kai leans in as Luther gives him a mug of hot chocolate, then retreats back to his chair.

KAI
So why do people forget?

LUTHER
Because forgetting's easy.
(beat)
And when we forget the warnings...
we feed the thing that waits where
the ground never healed.

Kai sips the hot chocolate.

LUTHER (CONT'D)
The stories weren't told to scare
us. They were so we'd remember what
happened — and stay away from
places that don't forget.

He continues carving the walking stick.

KAI
When does the beast come out?

Luther stops carving. Looks at him.

LUTHER
When the ground remembers.
(beat)
And it doesn't forget the ones who
woke it.

KAI
If it remembers us, can we make it
forget?

He taps the sketchbook with his knife handle, a faint smile, proud.

LUTHER
So you draw it, hm? Better than
letting it sit in the dark with no
name at all.

EXT. COUNTY ROAD - ELKHORN WISCONSIN - 2025 - PRE-DAWN

Fog sprawls across blacktop like spilled breath. Towering pines stand sentinel on both sides. A faded road sign reads: BRAY ROAD — a threshold between known and unknown.

Headlights slice through the mist.

A minivan hums into frame, dented, its muffler rattling.

INT. MINIVAN - MOVING - CONTINUOUS

Inside, MARCUS HARJO (16), Ho-Chunk, local high school football hero, drums the wheel to classic rock. A makeshift BEAST costume and foam claws on the seat beside him.

His phone, mounted on the dash, shows a group chat: KAI, LINA, MARCUS — last text from Marcus: a blurry selfie in the costume, “You owe me for this, assholes.”

He takes a puff from his vape, and glances down: NO SIGNAL.

He sighs, flicks the screen dark.

Then, a THUD.

The van JOLTS. Marcus jerks upright.

MARCUS
Shit...

He checks the rearview. Nothing.

EXT. BRAY ROAD - CONTINUOUS

The van pulls to the shoulder. Door creaks open.

Marcus steps out. Hoodie up. Uneasy. He circles the vehicle. Stops.

There, in the mist, A DEER. Splayed across the road. Its eyes are glassy, untouched by violence. The chest cavity gapes open, hollowed as if something reached inside and extracted its very essence.

Marcus backs up, freaked out.

MARCUS
Nope. Nope nope nope...

He hears something that isn’t a growl: a human-ish inhale behind him. He turns, the deer’s eyes blink.

Marcus GASPS, stumbles into his van, SLAMS the door.

The Minivan Peels out.

IN THE REARVIEW, the deer hasn't moved. But something stands behind it now. Tall. Watching. Gone in a blink.

SMASH TO:

TITLE CARD: THE HOLLOWING

FADE TO:

EXT. BRAY ROAD - EARLY FRIDAY MORNING - HALLOWEEN WEEKEND

Low fog bleeds across the cracked two-lane road. Pine silhouettes jag into the sky. The sun hasn't broken, only bruised the horizon.

A POLICE CRUISER idles behind a parked flatbed truck. Orange cones flicker in the half-light. Traffic is waved around by a DEPUTY (40s, stiff, caffeinated). He yawns, adjusting his vest.

DETECTIVE RIOS THUNDERCLOUD (50s), Ho-Chunk, weathered, sharp-eyed, calm.

He stands near the deer carcass. What's left of it. The scene is being scrubbed, not forgotten.

Two WisDOT WORKERS lay down a black tarp. One dry-heaves. The other doesn't blink.

DEPUTY
Another hoax?

RIOS
You ever see a prankster hollow out a rib cage that clean?

The deputy offers no answer. Rios crouches beside the carcass, the chest cavity peeled open like wet paper. Bones snapped like twigs.

RIOS (CONT'D)
That's not hunting. That's staged.

DEPUTY
Could be some psycho filming a snuff doc for clicks.

The DEPUTY kicks dirt over a blood trail.

DEPUTY (CONT'D)
It's the first night of Beast Fest.
You know what people are gonna say.

RIOS
Yeah. That it's back.

Wind gusts. Rios's coat flutters. He stands.

A beat.

DEPUTY
You think it's real?

RIOS
I know what I don't want to think.

The WisDOT team hauls the tarp-covered body toward the flatbed. Blood drips through the seams.

Rios turns back to the woods. Pines whisper. Fog retreats deeper. Watching.

CUT TO:

EXT. TOWN SQUARE - SUN DOWN - BEAST FEST OPENING NIGHT

Full Moon. The celebration begins. A chilled mist curls across the fields. JACK-O'-LANTERNS flicker in windows. The town of Elkhorn has transformed for its annual BEAST FESTIVAL.

Costumed kids chase each other under STRING LIGHTS looped across old brick buildings. RUSTED METAL SCULPTURES of the BEAST loom over booths selling funnel cakes and ROADKILL ON A STICK.

The local high school band limps through a minor key version of Monster Mash.

Rows of tents host bizarre sideshows. Beast-shaped soap. "Real" Beast tracks. Signage reading: "CAUGHT IN 4K," the vendor shilling faux found footage. Beneath the carnival's charm, something feels viscerally wrong... like the whole town's laughing at a funeral.

Marcus, works a PHOTO BOOTH snapping pics of tourists in front of a painted BRAY ROAD BACKDROP, featuring claw marks and moonlit woods.

EXT. TOWN SQUARE - NIGHT

A BEAST COSTUME CONTEST is underway. TEENS in homemade fur suit abominations stomp across a makeshift stage.

Kai Blackdeer, now seventeen, thoughtful, haunted, sketchbook tucked under arm, stands near the edge of the crowd. He watches through the lens of someone who doesn't find any of this funny.

Beside him, ROWAN KINNEY (18), non-native, wide grin, local royalty in a vintage varsity jacket. His family owns half the block. His grandfather named the street they're on.

ROWAN
(whispers to Kai)
Ten bucks on the one with the dog muzzle and ski goggles.

Kai doesn't respond. He's sketching the stage.

ROWAN (CONT'D)
You're still mad.

KAI
No. Not mad.

ROWAN
You think we're mocking it.

KAI
A little.

They both glance toward the MAIN STAGE, a TEEN GIRL in a glowing-eyed beast mask dancing. CHEERS. Applause.

ROWAN
You ever think about how weird it is? Like... if it's real, we've been throwing a festival for something that keeps killing people.

He swallows, a shadow crossing his face.

ROWAN (CONT'D)
Eli said that once. I laughed at him.
(pause)
Maybe we've all been laughing too long.

Kai stares back at the stage. A flicker of something behind his eyes.

EXT. FESTIVAL SIDE LOT - LATER

A rusting pickup truck turned into a mobile haunt, THE BEAST'S DEN. Cheap animatronics. Screams inside.

LINA DECORAH (17), Ho-Chunk, with a burning need to belong, exits the haunt laughing. Her denim jacket is covered in safety pins and patches.

EZRA FUNMAKER (19), half Ho-Chunk, twitchy, older, camera always recording. He films Lina with a handheld camcorder.

EZRA
You looked scared.

LINA
That's how I look when I laugh.

EZRA
You know laughter's a trauma response?

LINA
So's filming everything.

They spot Kai and Rowan near a food cart. Join them.

LINA (CONT'D)
I'm still shaking. That animatronic looked too much like my ex.

ROWAN
That's why I brought you here. For closure.

They all laugh.

Kai eyes a nearby vendor selling BEAST BITES beef jerky.

KAI
They'll sell anything if you slap a claw on it.

LINA
Says the guy who drew the original Beast Fest T-shirt design.

KAI
Yeah. Before...

He trails off. Silence settles. Lina watches him, concerned.

EZRA
You ever think we never really talk about him? Eli?

ROWAN
We're not doing this here.

EZRA
I mean, this was his thing. Remember the night he said he saw it?

KAI
He saw something.

ROWAN
He was high. We were all high.

LINA
You still remember it, though.

ROWAN
We were kids. I should've listened.
(beat)
We all should've.

A long pause. They all watch as the BEAST PARADE begins.

Local kids in fur and cardboard stomp down Main Street with sparklers. A float shaped like a pickup truck crushed by claw marks lumbers past. Adults cheer.

Kai watches with a blank expression. His hand tightens around his sketchbook.

EXT. HILL OVERLOOKING TOWN - LATER

The teens sit in the bed of Ezra's rusted pickup, looking out over the glowing town. Music and small fireworks in the distance.

ROWAN
This year feels different.

EZRA
Because it is.

ROWAN
I mean, what if we actually went through with it? Like for real.

Kai stiffens.

LINA
Through with what?

ROWAN
Finding the Beast. Going back out to that hollow off Bray Road if we have to.

KAI
Don’t joke.

EZRA
He’s not.

ROWAN
It’s Halloween. Five years since Eli disappeared out there.

EZRA
They called those sightings in 2018 and 2020 hoaxes.

KAI
They called Eli a hoax.

ROWAN
Whatever else, we go out there for Eli. To learn what really happened.

LINA
And you think walking back to the place they pulled him from is the move now? I don’t know if Eli wanted that.

ROWAN
It’s time. We’ve told the stories. Made the shirts. I want the real answer. For him. For us.

EZRA
Or maybe the town keeps giving it a stage.

The others stare.

EZRA (CONT’D)
Kidding. Mostly.

KAI
We’re not giving it anything anymore.
(beat)
(MORE)

KAI (CONT'D)
My brother said the Beast looked at him. Not like an animal hunts. Like it recognized him.

ROWAN
Look, I was the last one with him. The night he said he saw it. I told him to shut up and pass the joint.
(beat, softer)
I don't know what I'm hoping to find. Maybe something that says I wasn't wrong to let him go home alone. Maybe we all get something answered.

Long silent beat as everyone lets that soak in.

The festival lights below them flicker slightly. The crowd cheers as a new music act is announced.

EZRA
What if it's not about the hollow? What if the Beast is already in town?

KAI
It's not in town.

ROWAN
Then let's go and find out what it knows about the rest of us.

LINA
Or what we've forgotten.

EXT. BRAY ROAD - NIGHT

Ezra's truck rattles along a dirt road flanked by cornfields. A THIN VEIL OF MIST clings to the earth. Headlights sweep through rows of skeletal stalks.

INT. EZRA'S TRUCK - CONTINUOUS

Rowan rides shotgun. Kai and Lina huddle in the truck bed, bundled in blankets. Ezra drives, one hand on the wheel, the other clutching his camcorder.

EZRA
(flicking the camera on)
Date stamp. October 30th, 11:42 PM. Bray Road. Weird... timestamp jumped.

ROWAN
Maybe we're not supposed to see what's next.

Kai watches the fields blur past. He blinks. For a moment, he sees his brother reflected in the glass.

FLASH:

ELI BLACKDEER (12), solemn-eyed, sitting in front of him—

BACK TO:

Kai blinks hard. The image is gone. Lina pulls him close.

LINA
(softly)
You okay?

KAI
Yeah.

EXT. WOODS NEAR HOLLOW - NIGHT

The truck veers off Bray Road and rumbles down a rutted service spur. TREES CROUCH tight over the hood.

Headlights sweep across:

- A RUSTED "ROAD WORK AHEAD" SIGN, half-buried.

- An old METAL PROJECT PLACARD on a bent post:

KINNEY CONSTRUCTION - BRAY ROAD IMPROVEMENT - 1991.

The letters are faded, riddled with pellet dents.

The truck stops at the edge of a clearing. Beyond, the ground sinks into a shallow crater, earth slumped and roots exposed. Mist curls along the drop like breath.

Locals call it THE HOLLOW.

They climb out. No one speaks.

Fireworks POP far off over town. Their glow feels wrong here.

Rowan's eyes catch the old PLACARD. He wipes mud from the metal with his sleeve. His last name stares back at him.

He flinches, shoves his hands in his pockets.

ROWAN
(into the silence)
We remember what we're doing?

Lina scans the tree line, then the scarred ground.

LINA
We're standing on your family's "improvement project."

Ezra lifts his camera, starts rolling.

EZRA
Low light test, take one. Hollow clearing off Bray Road. Kinney land.

Kai steps toward the sinkhole. Kneels. Fingers sift the soil at the rim.

The silence is absolute. No rustling leaves. No insect hum. No birdsong.

KAI
(quiet)
No birds.

ROWAN
Means nothing else wants to be here.

Kai rises. Looks out over the Hollow: a collapsed slope, a dark wound in the hillside.

On one side, a busted CONCRETE CULVERT juts from the dirt, snapped clean. Rebar claws toward the air.

Fresh TIRE TRACKS from heavy machinery score the mud. Fluorescent SURVEY PAINT scars the trunks. A MODERN BARRICADE SAWHORSE lies on its side, reflective tape cracked.

KAI
This place never healed. Not from what they did to it.

Lina's gaze lands on the tire ruts that cut straight toward a jagged GAP where the slope fell in. A rough, irregular opening about the size of a door. Roots hang like torn nerves across the hole. Darkness breathes underneath.

LINA
They were here again. Not just in the nineties.

ROWAN
My dad said the county wanted another pass at the drainage.

He hears himself. The words taste like metal.

ROWAN (CONT'D)
Voice mail stuff. They never said the ground was already like this.

He cannot meet Kai's eyes.

Kai steps to the edge, studying the gap.

KAI
Eli kept drawing this curve. This exact line.
(beat)
He said it felt like it was calling him.

Lina slips a thin woven bracelet from her wrist. Hand-made, worn smooth.

LINA
My aunt always said you don't walk into a place that took something from you empty-handed.

She kneels, sets the bracelet on a rock at the rim, between old survey paint and exposed roots.

Wind stirs. Leaves spiral in a pattern that feels wrong, then fall flat.

A sound rises from the gap. Not quite breath, not quite growl. A low exhale from somewhere deep and unseen.

The kids freeze.

ROWAN
(whisper)
Tell me you heard that.

KAI
It knows we're here.

Ezra swings the camera toward the hole.

THROUGH VIEWFINDER - the gap, the drooping roots, blackness that seems to drink the light.

A faint BLUE DISTORTION flickers at the edge of frame, hovers around ROWAN'S SILHOUETTE, then disappears.

Ezra lowers the camera, shaken.

EZRA
Something in there likes your last name.

Rowan’s jaw tightens. Shame and anger war behind his eyes.

ROWAN
Feels like it’s reading me.

Lina looks from Rowan to the Kinney sign, then to the freshly torn earth.

LINA
Well, the paperwork said it could.

Kai moves closer to the gap, drawn and repelled at once. Mist coils up around his shoes.

KAI
We didn’t come. We got pulled. Same as Eli.

Ezra steps back, filming from a safer angle that does not feel safe at all.

THROUGH VIEWFINDER:

- The cracked culvert.

- The survey paint.

- The bracelet, tiny in the dirt.

For a split second, deep inside the black: a pale face, teenaged, hollow-eyed. ELI.

Ezra gasps.

He yanks the camera down.

EZRA
He’s in there. I saw him.

ROWAN
You saw his face in a hole my family punched into the ground.

His voice cracks. He swipes at his eyes, too rough.

ROWAN (CONT'D)
Every time I think I'm not them, I find another sign with my name on it nailed to the nightmare.

KAI
You're here. They never stood here.

Their eyes meet. No neat forgiveness, only something raw and real.

Wind knifes over the clearing. The old project placard rattles on its bent post.

Ezra's hand shakes on the camera. He flips on NIGHT MODE.

THROUGH NIGHTVISION: Faces bleach ghost-pale. The bracelet glows faintly. The gap turns into a perfect black circle. Something STANDS inside that circle. Tall. Wrong. Two-legged. Watching Rowan.

Kai sees it on the tiny screen. His hand clamps over the lens, killing the image.

KAI (CONT'D)
Don't feed it with faces.

Ezra staggers back.

EZRA
We need to go. Now.

A sound tears through the Hollow. Half human scream, half animal howl, too close to name.

Mist rears like a living thing.

Lina grabs Kai's sleeve. Rowan backs away from the edge as the soil crumbles an inch under his heel, like the ground reached for him.

They bolt for the truck, breath ragged, candles of their flashlights bouncing wild on trees and old signs with KINNEY stamped across them.

The Hollow exhales behind them. The open gap waits.

EXT. WOODS - MOMENTS LATER

Mist thickens, clinging low like breath that does not belong. The teens SPRINT through the trees. Branches WHIP and SNAP behind them, shapes in panic.

ROWAN (O.S.)
Go, go!

LINA (O.S.)
Where's Kai?

EXT. WOODS - CONTINUOUS

KAI STUMBLES hard. Hits the ground. His SKETCHBOOK thuds beside him, pages fanning like wounded wings.

The FLASHLIGHT in his hand FLICKERS. DIES.

Silence.

The trees lean inward. Listening. Watching. Hungry.

Kai turns slowly —

ELI stands in the mist.

Still. Wrong. His outline warps at the edges. Not quite human, not quite monster. Eyes too wide. Smile too still.

KAI
(soft)
You're not him.

ELI
I remember him.

The voice layers — Eli on the surface, something ancient and ravenous under it.

Kai staggers backward. Breath shallow, sharp.

His dead flashlight sputters once, throwing fractured shadow across Eli's face.

SUDDENLY — The SKETCHBOOK SHAKES on the ground. Pages whip open like frantic fingers searching memory.

Kai watches, transfixed, as the drawing of THE HOLLOW curls at the edges.

Darkness seeps out of the lines. Not ink. Not shadow. Something between remembrance and hunger.

He reaches out —

The PAGE PEELS FREE. Hovers. Suspended like ash that refuses to fall.

His breath catches, then pulls inward too fast — like the air reverses.

Leaves TWIST UP around him. Wind curls inward, spiraling toward the floating page.

Kai drops to his knees.

The page TWISTS. The sketch has changed —

THE BEAST now faces forward. Its eyes open.

Behind it in the drawing: faint SURVEY STAKES. A crooked KINNEY CONSTRUCTION SIGN.

The eyes on the page BLINK.

KAI GASPS.

A low HUM rises from the trees. Not sound. Pressure. The air remembering something.

FOOTSTEPS. Fast. Breaking the spell.

EZRA (O.S.)
Kai!

LINA (O.S.)
Shit, are you hurt?

They BURST through the trees. Rowan drops beside him, steadying him.

Lina kneels, hands cupping Kai's face. Her touch lingers — diagnostic, then something deeper. He TREMBLES beneath her palms.

KAI
(whispers)
We didn't find it.
(beat)
It found me.

He clutches the sketchbook.

The torn page is gone.

CUT TO:

INT. EZRA'S TRUCK - NIGHT

Doors SLAM.

Engine stutters, then ROARS to life. HEADLIGHTS slice through mist. The truck PEELS AWAY.

IN THE REARVIEW — THE HOLLOW. Still. Sagging. Swallowed by trees.

The mist moves in ways that feel wrong.

INT. EZRA'S TRUCK - MOVING - CONTINUOUS

The truck barrels down the highway. Dust curls in its wake. Town lights glow distant, swallowed by forest.

Ezra white-knuckles the wheel. Rowan rides shotgun, fists tight in his lap.

In the bed, Lina holds Kai under a blanket. He pulls her closer without realizing. Both stare into nothing. No one speaks.

EXT. ABANDONED GAS STATION - LATER

The truck rolls into a DESERTED GAS STATION on the edge of town. Flickering NEON fights a losing battle with the dark. Windows boarded. Pumps dead.

INT. GAS STATION PARKING LOT - CONTINUOUS

Doors open. The teens spill out. Staggered. Rattled.

Ezra walks a few paces, drops to the asphalt. Hands shaking. He flips the CAMCORDER open. Rewinds. Pauses. Finger hovering over PLAY.

ROWAN
What the fuck was that?

No one answers.

Lina's voice comes quiet, scared.

LINA
You all saw it, right? Eli…
standing there?

Kai stares straight ahead.

EZRA
It looked like him. His jacket. His
walk.

KAI
Whatever that was, it wasn’t him.

ROWAN
Then what was it? What did we walk into?

LINA
(voice shaking)
It was already moving. Felt like it knew us before we ever got there.

ROWAN
(to Ezra)
You seriously want to watch that?

EZRA
We need to see it. Need to know if it’s real.

He hits PLAY.

ON SCREEN: Dirt flying. Ragged breathing. A FLASH OF ELI. Eyes blank. Staring straight down the lens.

They all recoil.

EZRA (CONT’D)
(whispers)
It saw me.

KAI
No. It wanted you to see it.

Silence stretches.

LINA
They cut that hill open and buried what happened. They covered it because they couldn’t look at it.

EZRA
I thought if I documented it we could name it. Make sense of it.
(beat)
This isn’t a story. It’s a wound.

ROWAN
So what now? We act like nothing happened?

EZRA
What if waking it up wasn’t the only thing we did?
(MORE)

EZRA (CONT'D)
(beat)
What if we gave it a way in?

They freeze.

LINA
You think it's… following us?

KAI
It knows us now. That is closer than following.

Ezra swallows, eyes on the camcorder.

LINA
(muttering)
Felt like it knew us already.

ROWAN
My family's name is on that road sign. On half the shit that cut this place up.
(beat)
I fucked up. I'm the one who pushed us to go. We need to go back. Cover whatever they opened. Burn the footage. Stop all of this.

EZRA
Can't. I set it to back up.

KAI
You what?

EZRA
Offsite. Auto sync. I didn't think—

Kai GRABS him, SLAMS him against the truck.

KAI
Delete it. Now.

EZRA
(terrified)
Okay! Okay!

Rowan dives in, shoving Kai back, holding him at arm's length.

ROWAN
Hey. He's your friend. You want to swing on somebody, start with me.

LINA
Kai—

Kai shakes. Chest rising and falling like he's holding back a sob.

Lina steps in front of him.

LINA (CONT'D)
(soft)
He's scared. We all are. Breathe.

A distant WAIL cuts through the night. Not human. Not animal.

Overhead, the NEON SIGN BUZZES, flares, then DIES. The lot drops into deeper DARKNESS.

That is enough.

They pile back into the truck. Quieter. Hollower.

Ezra turns the key. The engine coughs, then catches.

The truck pulls away from the dead station, swallowed by road and trees.

CUT TO:

EXT. EZRA'S DRIVEWAY - NIGHT

The truck fishtails into Ezra's gravel drive. Headlights slice across the overgrown lawn. Light flickers from the mobile home.

INT. EZRA'S MOBILE HOME - NIGHT

The cramped space hums with old monster obsessions. Wires. VHS towers. Rubber masks on nails. Faded BEAST FEST posters. Stacks of local papers leaning like tired sentries.

The front door stands triple-locked. A chair wedged under the knob.

Lina sinks into the couch. Blankets and pizza boxes slide to the floor.

LINA
How do you even sleep in here?

Ezra ignores her. Rips the camera strap off his neck, hands shaking.

EZRA
We don’t go back. Ever.

KAI
It knows we were there.

ROWAN
We erase it. All of it.

Silence. The wall clock ticks loud.

Something shifts outside. A tire crunch. A small scrape. Present.

ROWAN (CONT’D)
You locked every door, right?

A long beat.

EZRA
(quiet)
There is no back door.

Ezra moves to a narrow hallway, drags down a ceiling ladder. Dust falls.

EZRA (CONT’D)
My dad stashed everything up here.
Beast Fest junk. Old clippings.
Every rumor he could print.

He disappears into the ATTIC CRAWLSPACE.

Boxes rustle. Something heavy thuds.

ROWAN
(calling up)
He was tracking it?

EZRA (O.S.)
Said somebody had to.

INT. EZRA’S MOBILE HOME - NIGHT - MOMENTS LATER

Ezra drops back down, hauling a weathered cardboard box.

Handwritten on the side: “TOWN FILES - HOLLOW / BRAY ROAD.”

He sets it on the coffee table. The others crowd in.

Ezra peels the lid open. POLAROIDS, yellowed NEWSPAPER CLIPPINGS, hand-drawn MAPS, crumpled NOTEBOOK PAGES.

Rowan reaches in first. Pulls a black-and-white photo.

Three younger HO-CHUNK MEN in work clothes, shovels in hand — LUTHER BLACKDEER, ELIJAH HARJO, RIOS' FATHER. Mud up to their knees.

Beside them, a white man in a KINNEY CONSTRUCTION jacket, hard hat under his arm. A low MOUND in the background. Trees. A faint, wrong shadow at the treeline.

ROWAN
(choked)
That's my grandpa.
Kinney Construction logo and
everything.

Kai leans closer.

KAI
Same hill. Same ground.

Lina studies the faces.

LINA
(low)
This isn't some old legend. This is
our parents' lifetime.

Ezra pulls a brittle folder marked: "1975-1987 - DISAPPEARANCES."

He flips it open. Three clipped obituaries. Notes in frantic pen.

EZRA
Three names. Always around October.
Every few years he circled back to
this same spot.

He unfolds a wrinkled MAP. Red ink spirals around one point close to BRAY ROAD. Scrawled over it in block letters: "HOLLOW / WOUND."

Kai feels the pull of it. He digs out his SKETCHBOOK, flips pages until his own drawing of the Hollow appears — slope, trees, that same uneasy curve of earth.

A SYMBOL sits near the top of his sketch, lines woven like roots.

LINA
(soft)
There. That mark. I've seen it.

KAI
My grandfather carved it on his cane... on everything actually. It’s his personal art, something he created. Viewed it as protection... or maybe a warning.

ROWAN
Warning about what?

Kai traces the symbol on the sketch.

KAI
He called it the Hollowing. Not a spirit. Not a god.
Something that waits
where the ground never healed.

Ezra digs deeper in the box. Finds a stained PHOTO of a stone slab half-buried in dirt. The same SYMBOL carved in the center.

Underneath, in Ezra’s dad’s handwriting: “CURSED EARTH. DON’T DISTURB.”

EZRA
My dad wrote that.
He loved dramatic warnings.

Lina stares at the words. At the hands in the photos. At the Kinney jacket.

LINA
The earth isn’t cursed.
It’s hurt. People did that.

Rowan’s grip tightens on the photo with his grandfather.

ROWAN
That road cut straight through a mound site.

Kai nods, eyes on the map.

KAI
County wanted pavement, not memory.
When they realized what they hit, they dumped fill, poured concrete, and called it sealed.

Rowan swallows.

ROWAN
Kinney crews poured that concrete.
Our trucks kept coming. New
utilities. New work orders.
My last name on the corner
of every permit. That's the name
it's staring at now.

No one rushes to comfort him. The weight sits with all of them.

Kai presses his fingers to the stone symbol in the photo.

KAI
Luther said it feeds on forgetting.
It mimics pain.
Wears the faces we lost.

ROWAN
So that thing wearing Eli's face-

KAI
Was what took him.
Not who he was.

A faint metallic SCREECH echoes outside. Distant. Wrong. Everyone stills.

Ezra edges to the blinds, peels one slat down. Darkness. The hint of a streetlight. Nothing obvious.

EZRA
(low)
Nothing out there.

Rowan does not buy it. His voice drops almost to a whisper.

ROWAN
It's in the cracks.
Same as these.

He taps the folder. The photos. The map.

Ezra sits again, the box between them like a wound.

EZRA
So what do we even hit?
You can't swing at fog.

Kai looks at the papers. At the names. At the dates.

KAI
We go where they hid it first. Ink.
Records. Land deeds.
(MORE)

KAI (CONT'D)
Every place they tried to file this out of sight.

LINA
The library.

KAI
Town archives. Old papers. Anything with our names and theirs on the same page.

Ezra glances at his CAMCORDER. Then at a battered LAPTOP perched on a milk crate.

He plugs the camera in with a frayed cable.

ON SCREEN: Folders — "BEAST_FEST_23," "HOLLOW_TEST," "BACKUP_SYNC."

His fingers shake on the trackpad.

EZRA
(to himself)
Cloud sync off. Local only.

He clicks. Icons grey out. He drags the latest clip into a folder labeled: "DO NOT ERASE."

A small pop-up appears in the corner: "PREVIOUS UPLOAD INCOMPLETE. RETRYING WHEN CONNECTED."

Ezra SLAMS the laptop lid. The alert disappears.

The kids sit in a small circle around the box. Generations of choices spread between them.

KAI
(quiet)
Tomorrow.
We drag their secrets into daylight.

They hold the silence together.

INT. EZRA'S MOBILE HOME - EARLY MORNING

Blue-grey seep of dawn. Frost claws at the thin windows. The air hangs cold and heavy.

Blankets and hoodies turn the floor into a nest of half-slept teens.

Rowan lies on his back, hood over his face. Ezra stares at the ceiling, eyes wide and red. Sleep never came.

Kai sits up first. Shoulders sore. He moves to the small window over the sink.

EXT. EZRA'S MOBILE HOME - CONTINUOUS (INTERCUT)

Outside: a thin strip of woods behind the trailer park. Mist braided between trees. No movement. No birds.

FLASHBACK:

EXT. WOODS - DUSK - YEARS AGO

Young KAI trails LUTHER BLACKDEER through dense trees. Luther's walking stick carries the same carved SYMBOL.

LUTHER
Some places exist outside time. You feel them before seeing them. When your hair lifts and your chest tightens... that's not fear.

BACK TO PRESENT:

Kai grips the counter. Breathes through that tightness.

Lina shuffles up beside him, wrapped in a blanket, hair wild, eyes soft with exhaustion.

LINA
You're up early.

KAI
Couldn't stay down.

She looks out with him. The mist. The trees. The quiet.

LINA
Thinking about last night?

KAI
Thinking about before that. What pulled us there.
Long before we got a driver's license.

She lets that sit a moment.

LINA
I felt it too. Thought it was anxiety. Night screams. Whatever the doctors wrote down.

KAI
Maybe it’s memory. Not ours alone. The kind everybody told us to ignore.

Their hands brush as they lean on the counter. Neither pulls away.

ROWAN (O.S.)
If you two kiss before coffee, I’m throwing myself through that window.

Lina huffs a laugh. Kai cracks an actual smile.

LINA
Morning, sunshine.

Rowan drags the hood off, squints at them.

Ezra finally blinks and rolls onto his side.

EZRA
What time is it?

KAI
Almost seven.

LINA
Library opens in an hour.

Ezra groans.

EZRA
Great. Nothing creepier than a courthouse records room. Except a library at eight a.m.

Rowan pushes himself up on his elbows.

ROWAN
Imagine being one of those books. Full of everybody’s worst choices, stuck on a shelf.

LINA
Sounds like you’re mad you can’t read.

Kai turns back to them, that tiny smile already fading into focus.

KAI
We hit records first. Obits. Land deeds. Old council minutes. Anything that ties the Hollow to Kinney, the county, the church, and our families.

Rowan sits up fully now. No joke in his face.

ROWAN
If my family's name is stamped on half of it, I need to see every page.

Ezra runs a hand through his hair.

EZRA
And if my dad's scribbles are anywhere in there, we pull those too.
No more secrets.

Lina nods. The fear in her eyes sits right beside resolve.

LINA
We bring the dead into daylight.
Names. Dates. Faces.
No more letting this thing feed on blanks.

Kai looks at each of them in turn.

KAI
We read everything.
Then we decide what goes back in the ground and what never does.

Off their faces — exhausted, scared, moving anyway —

CUT TO:

EXT. BRAY ROAD OVERPASS - MORNING

Fog clings to the roadside.

A SECOND DEER lies in the ditch. Gutted. Arranged. Empty eyes aimed at the grey sky.

Rios crouches nearby, gloved, worn thin. He studies the scene like a memory he hoped stayed buried.

DETECTIVE RUIZ, Ho-Chunk, mid-40s, practical and wired on coffee, steps up beside him.

RUIZ
That's two in twenty-four hours. Whatever's doing it stopped hiding.

Rios looks over the careful positioning of the body.

RIOS
It's not the killing. It's the way it's left.
(beat)
Someone's sending a message.

RUIZ
To who?

Rios glances toward the treeline, toward the distant rise of the Hollow

He pulls a plastic EVIDENCE SLEEVE from his coat. Inside: a TORN PAGE.

A charcoal drawing. A sagging hill of earth with branching roots, something watching under the soil line. In the corner: K. BLACKDEER.

RIOS
Found this near the Hollow.

RUIZ
One of the kids?

Rios lifts his department phone. Snaps a quick PHOTO of the drawing in the sleeve… then of the deer in the ditch. Screen glow washes his tired face for an instant.

RIOS
Kai Blackdeer. Luther Blackdeer's grandkid.

RUIZ
You think he's involved?

RIOS
I think he's in the crosshairs.

He stands. Scans the empty road, horizon bleeding into town limits.

RIOS (CONT'D)
Find out if anyone's seen him. My bet? He's hunting answers.

RUIZ
Where?

RIOS
Library. Old files.
(beat)
Places everyone thinks are empty.

Off the second deer. Blood drying into the dirt.

CUT TO:

EXT. ELKHORN PUBLIC LIBRARY - MORNING

Soft amber light behind tall windows. A brick box of memory at the edge of Main Street.

INT. LIBRARY - RESEARCH ROOM - LATER

Fluorescents hum. Old COMPUTERS. MICROFILM READERS.

Kai scrolls through microfilm. Headlines flicker:

ON SCREEN - “ANOTHER MUTILATION ON BRAY ROAD”

ON SCREEN - “STRANGE FIGURE SEEN NEAR WOODS”

ON SCREEN - “CEREMONIAL MOUND UNTOUCHED FOR CENTURIES”

Ezra leans in beside him, phone up for the occasional snap.

Lina studies a LAMINATED MAP of regional mounds. Several are crossed out in RED PEN.

Rowan slumps in a creaky chair. Hoodie up. Beast Fest group chat open on his phone, thumb hovering, eyes elsewhere.

LINA
(soft, reading)
There were thousands of effigy mounds across this part of Wisconsin.

Her finger moves over the red X marks.

LINA (CONT’D)
Half of these got flattened before anyone bothered to list them.

Kai taps the glass of the microfilm viewer.

ON SCREEN - 1991 ARTICLE: “TEEN GIRL ATTACKED ON BRAY ROAD. NEAR SITE RECENTLY EXCAVATED BY HIGHWAY CREW.”

KAI
Highway crew dug near Bray in ninety-one.

Ezra snaps a PHOTO of the screen.

EZRA
Low-res truth still counts.

He scrolls. Dates blur past.

EZRA (CONT’D)
Eighty-nine. Ninety-one. Ninety-three. Three cases, then nothing till the late two-thousands.
(beat)
Always in runs of three.

Rowan glances at the LAMINATED MAP in Lina’s hands.

INSERT - His POV: tiny printed text by one red X: “KINNEY CONST. SITE PREP - 1979.”

He snaps his phone screen dark.

ROWAN
So every time somebody digs where they weren’t supposed to...

LINA
Something answers.

A SHADOW falls over the table.

RIOS (O.S.)
Took the town thirty years to ask those questions.

They turn.

Rios stands in the aisle. Tired eyes. No smile.

INT. LIBRARY - PRIVATE STUDY ROOM - MOMENTS LATER

A cramped room of old tables and bad paint. A single narrow window. Door closed.

The kids sit crowded together. Rios stands near the door, one hand on the knob by reflex, then lets it go.

He pulls a TORN SKETCHBOOK PAGE from his coat. Lays it on the table.

Kai's drawing of the Hollow. Roots. Darkness pressing up from underneath.

RIOS
I remember when your brother Eli vanished.

He looks at Kai.

RIOS (CONT'D)
You were twelve. Sat in this library with that book in your hands.
(beat)
Didn't say a word.

Kai's gaze sticks to the drawing.

KAI
We left in a hurry. I didn't know it fell out.

RIOS
The drawing bothers me more than the litter.

CLOSE ON THE SKETCH - lines dark and insistent, pressure under loam.

FLASHBACK:

EXT. FOREST CLEARING - DUSK - EARLY 1990s

Ash hangs low. TREES charred around a resealed mound of earth.

A younger LUTHER BLACKDEER. ELIJAH HARJO. A third man in a deputy jacket, patch reading THUNDERCLOUD. Rios's father.

They stand at the mound's edge. No ceremony. No words at first.

Beneath the soil, a faint HUM.

YOUNG LUTHER
(quiet)
Some things belong to the ground.

The men trade a look. Agreement without comfort.

BACK TO PRESENT:

Rios watches Kai, Ezra, Lina, Rowan. The next generation set in the same air.

RIOS
My father was that third man.

He taps the torn page.

RIOS (CONT'D)
County wanted a new road. Church wanted a clean view. Developers wanted contracts. Three Ho-Chunk men were leaned on hard and agreed to silence they'd regret.

Rowan flinches - the Kinney map note still fresh in his head.

RIOS (CONT'D)
My father called it an anchor. Then he helped them bury it under concrete, like hiding could hold what happened still.

LINA
Mounds were never meant for that.

RIOS
They held people steady when everything else moved. Then the county and the church covered their fear, and the anchor cracked into a wound.

He finally sits. The room feels smaller.

RIOS (CONT'D)
Near the end, he told me it felt like a debt. Every time someone tried to cover what happened, the cost landed on someone who never agreed to pay it.

A beat. The kids take that in.

KAI
We went out there to see where it started.

RIOS
You walked into a place that already remembered you.
Luther. Elijah. My father.
Your families.

Rowan stares at the sketch.

ROWAN
And Kinney.
(beat)
Our trucks. Our contracts.

Rios nods once.

RIOS
That name sits on half the permits in this county. The land keeps score even when the files go missing.

Ezra swallows.

EZRA
So what are we supposed to do?

RIOS
I can pull patrol cars. I can push reports through. I can't tell the church what to admit. Father Grady can.

LINA
He knows about the Hollow?

RIOS
He knows about an older sinkhole west of here. Mission Ridge. Old graveyard where they stacked bodies after a sickness.
(beat)
Folks called that place the Mouth.

That lands.

RIOS (CONT'D)
My father said if the hill ever started pulling again, Grady would have a page Elijah left for him.

Rios takes out a worn BUSINESS CARD. Slides it to Kai.

RIOS (CONT'D)
My direct line. No switchboard. You see anything, hear anything, you call.

Rowan eyes the card.

ROWAN
You know you could text that.

RIOS
Paper lives longer than a phone.

Rowan shuts up.

Kai pockets the card, fingers tight.

RIOS (CONT'D)
You stirred something that was already moving.
(beat)
It hasn't finished with you.

He opens the door. Pauses in the frame.

RIOS (CONT'D)
Go see Grady.
(beat)
Then decide how you answer that hill.

He exits.

Silence.

Ezra stares at the sketch.

EZRA
He's scared.

LINA
Good. So are we.

Kai folds the page and card into his jacket.

KAI
St. Agnes then.

CUT TO:

EXT. TOWN SQUARE - LATER

Golden autumn light. Beast Fest in full throttle.

MARCHING BAND tuning up. Kids with BEAST-PAINTED faces. Vendors hawk funnel cakes and "I SAW THE BEAST" shirts.

A hulking WOODEN BEAST EFFIGY looms over the lawn, teeth bared for selfies.

Kai, Lina, Rowan, Ezra slip along the edge of the crowd like a shadow line. Out of step with the noise.

A TOUR GUIDE in a cheap cloak waves a plastic lantern at a cluster of tourists.

TOUR GUIDE
Stay on the path down Bray Road
and they say the Beast walks
right behind you...

Rowan mutters as they pass.

ROWAN
No one mentions what it does
when you stop walking.

A PAPER FLYER spins on the wind, slaps against Ezra's chest. He peels it off.

INSERT FLYER: "COME FACE THE HOLLOW! TOURS DEPART AT DUSK."

Ezra starts to lift his phone, stops himself. Crumples the flyer instead.

EZRA
They turned it into an attraction.

Lina looks from the flyer to the effigy, then to the kids posing for photos.

LINA
Slapped a Beast on a t-shirt
and called it a legend.

Kai watches a kid in a plastic mask gnaw cotton candy where the town once held vigils.

KAI
(to himself)
They built a party on top
of a wound.

Music swells behind them. Laughter. Fry oil. None of it reaches their faces.

They move off along a side street.

CUT TO:

EXT. ST. AGNES CHURCH - MOMENTS LATER

Gothic stone, weathered and stubborn. Stained glass throws fractured color across the walkway.

Strips of faded cloth tie along the fence, names inked in marker. Weathered prayers flapping in a weak breeze.

The kids approach. The air feels denser here. Sound dulled.

They slip through the gate. A faint chill crawls over their skin.

INT. ST. AGNES CHURCH - CONTINUOUS

The sanctuary stands empty. Pews in neat rows. Candles half-burned.

Light from stained glass paints the aisle in broken colors.

The four settle into the front pew. Small against all that stone.

Kai checks his phone. Signal icon flickers, then: NO SERVICE.

KAI
(low)
Rios said you'd know what this was.

A MATCH SCRAPES behind them. A candle blooms at the side altar.

FATHER GRADY (60s) steps from the shadows. Broad shoulders under a worn cassock. Eyes that have seen too much.

He lights another candle as he walks.

FATHER GRADY
Detective Thundercloud said the hill started calling again.
(beat)
I prayed he was wrong.

Rowan turns in the pew.

ROWAN
He said you're the one who still tells the truth.

FATHER GRADY
I tell memory. Truth slides around whoever holds the microphone.

He lowers himself into the pew across from them. Hears his knees crack.

FATHER GRADY (CONT'D)
This ridge was Ho-Chunk ground long before anyone stacked stone and stained glass on it. Watchposts. Burials. Prayers.

He looks up at the crucifix, then at the kids.

FATHER GRADY (CONT'D)
Your elders taught me the mounds were made to honor their ancestors.
(beat)
Men in my collar line laid bricks over those mounds and called it progress.

Kai's eyes stay on the floor.

KAI
The ground never settled.

FATHER GRADY
No.

He gestures toward the side wall.

FATHER GRADY (CONT'D)
In thirty-three a night watchman stood where you're sitting. Told the priest he saw a shape digging at the edge of the hill. Wolf head. Man body. Sheriff wrote "wolves" in the report anyway.

He leads them toward a bank of CANDLES. Melted wax pools thick at the base.

FATHER GRADY (CONT'D)
West of here stands Mission Ridge. Old graveyard from a flu year the town likes to forget.

He walks toward a STAINED GLASS PANEL. Between blues and reds, a vague BEAST-LIKE FIGURE hides in the pattern, easy to miss.

FATHER GRADY (CONT'D)
They moved bodies there from three parishes. Cut through older graves, reburied them in neat rows. The ground sank, formed a hollow.
(MORE)

FATHER GRADY (CONT'D)
(beat)
Folks who still remembered Ho-Chunk stories started calling that sinkhole the Mouth.

Kai steps closer to him.

KAI
What sits there now?

FATHER GRADY
A few stones. A broken altar. A place that never stopped sagging.

He reaches into his coat. Produces a CHARRED PAGE, edges blackened, a symbol in charcoal at the center. Luther's mark.

FATHER GRADY (CONT'D)
Elijah Harjo left this in the parish files for me. Said if the hill ever started pulling again, send anyone stubborn enough to listen back to Mission Ridge.

He presses the page into Kai's hand.

FATHER GRADY (CONT'D)
If you go there, leave everything you can. Take memory. Nothing else.

Ezra shifts, uneasy.

EZRA
We recorded what the Hollow did to Eli.
(beat)
We thought naming it would help.

Grady's gaze drops to the pocket where Ezra's phone sticks out.

FATHER GRADY
The hill already knows those faces. No photos in that graveyard. Some things grow stronger every time a lens blinks.

He moves back toward the altar.

FATHER GRADY (CONT'D)
I remember your brother.

He looks at Kai.

FATHER GRADY (CONT'D)
This church filled wall to wall. You sat front row, clutching that sketchbook.

His gaze shifts to Rowan.

FATHER GRADY (CONT'D)
You shook so hard the pew rattled.

Rowan looks away. Heat in his face.

FATHER GRADY (CONT'D)
I lit a candle for Eli every day that winter. Then the town turned the story into masks and merch. Forgetting gives things room.

He sets a new CANDLE on the rack. Lights it with care.

FATHER GRADY (CONT'D)
I keep names here.
(beat)
That is how I fight it.

He whispers Eli's name under his breath.

FATHER GRADY (CONT'D)
You can stay as long as you like.

He nods once to each of them, then retreats into the side chapel.

INT. CHURCH - LATER

The sanctuary holds a thick quiet.

Rowan sits in the front pew, eyes on the wax pooling.

Lina studies the hidden beast shape in the stained glass, expression set.

Ezra opens his messages: "WHERE ARE YOU?" texts stack from his mom, from Marcus. He locks the screen without replying.

Kai stands near the candle rack, charred page in hand. His thumb traces the charcoal lines.

KAI
(low)
If we find what they used to hold it in place before, we can fix what cracked.
(beat)
And stop pretending it started with us.

Lina joins him. Their shoulders almost touch.

LINA
Then we start with the Mouth.

Off their faces — scared, tired, moving anyway —

CUT TO:

EXT. TRUCK - MOVING - DAY

The truck cuts through golden countryside. Trees blur. The road bends toward darker woods.

INT. TRUCK - MOVING - CONTINUOUS

Lina turns a small cross over in her hands. Silent. Rowan stares out the window, leg bouncing.

Ezra drives. His phone sits face down on the dash, map app open, the blue route fading into gray as the signal bar drops.

EZRA
We sure about this?

KAI
(meeting Lina’s eyes)
We’re past sure.

She lies her head on Kai’s shoulder.

ROWAN
Yeah, I guess we’re in it now.

The trees thicken. The light flattens.

They drive on.

CUT TO:

EXT. ABANDONED FARMHOUSE - LATE AFTERNOON

Golden light feels heavy. Wind cuts through dry cornfields.

The truck pulls up beside a crumbling barn. Beyond it, GRAVESTONES. Tilted. Half-swallowed by weeds.

They step out. The wind stills.

EZRA
This is where they found that nightwatchman.
(beat)
Before they shifted everything up to St. Agnes.

KAI
Then this is where the first damage started.

Rowan looks toward the gravestones.

ROWAN
Kinney crews poured the access road. My family signed the papers.

Lina finds Kai's hand and squeezes.

Deep under the soil, a faint pressure. Not heard. Felt.

A breeze slices through the corn, bending the stalks in one sharp, silent wave.

EXT. ABANDONED GRAVEYARD - LATER

Golden light filters through gnarled trees. Overgrown grass swallows crooked gravestones. Iron fences warp at odd angles.

The group stands at the edge.

KAI
Grady said this hill was older than the town. They stuck a church beside it so no one had to look too close.

ROWAN
To keep it quiet?

EZRA
To keep it hidden.

They step through the rusted gate. It MOANS.

Lina shivers.

LINA
This place feels wrong.

They move carefully. Graves lean at strange angles. A tree splits a collapsed tomb, roots cracking stone.

Kai stops at a half-sunken marker. Brushes moss aside.

CLOSE ON: A weathered cross. MERCY. 1894.

His fingers linger on the stone—

The image STUTTERS.

FLASH:

HOOVES pounding earth. Smoke. Screams. A mound torn open. Blood smears stone. Men with shovels move in shadow.

BACK TO:

Kai gasps, stumbles back. Breath ragged.

LINA (CONT'D)
What did you see?

KAI
(shaken)
Something old.
(beat)
Someone else's memory.
Not mine.

Nearby, a SYMBOL carved into stone. Same as Luther's cane. Faded, yet there.

KAI (CONT'D)
Same mark.
(beat)
He was here.

A tight, ancient whisper rides the wind. Not words. Pressure.

LINA
I hate this hill.

ROWAN
You think he ever told the whole story?

KAI
I think he survived enough of it.

Ezra paces near a collapsed altar. Kneels.

EZRA
There's wax. Drips on the stone. Someone's been lighting candles out here.

ROWAN
Locals?

EZRA
Or someone trying to keep it from swallowing more.

KAI
Or feeding it.

A CROW drops from a branch, lands, and pecks at the dirt. It yanks up something red and wet. Not a worm. Meat. It flies off.

CRACK.

A twig snaps.

They whirl.

Nothing.

From the tree line, a FIGURE steps forward. Human. Elderly. Weathered. Ho-Chunk. LUTHER BLACKDEER.

He stops a few yards away.

Sound drains. No birds. No wind. Only breath.

A shaft of light slips through the trees and catches his shoulders. The grass under his boots stays flat. No bend. No imprint.

LUTHER
You should not be here.

KAI
(quiet, steps forward)
Grandfather?

Doubt flickers across Kai's face.

KAI (CONT'D)
You died.

Luther studies them. Eyes sharp. He moves closer. His steps make no sound.

Lina and Kai trade a look. Her grip tightens.

LUTHER
You opened what we tried to cover.
(beat)
It knows your shapes now.

LINA
(whisper, to Kai)
He never talked like that.

Luther’s head tilts. For a moment his voice warbles, Eli’s tone hiding under it.

LUTHER
You broke the patch. Stirred what was buried. This is what comes when you trespass.

KAI
He never called it trespass either.

Luther’s smile feels wrong. Too many teeth.

LUTHER
It is a wound that learned to walk.

Kai shakes his head.

KAI
When I was seven you told me we never blame the land. We blame what was done to it. The county crews and developers who ripped open our burial mounds. You never would’ve said a wound that learned to walk.
(beat)
You’re not my grandfather.

The figure’s face twitches and it glitches hard once called out. The skin seems to lag behind the muscles.

ROWAN
What are you?

A faint ripple passes over Luther’s features, as if someone pulls another face underneath.

LUTHER
You carry what it takes. That is the price.

EZRA
Price for who? You, or it?

The figure’s eyes flare for a heartbeat with the same emptiness as the deer.

LUTHER
The hill remembers what was done in your names.
(staring at Rowan)
Concrete remembers who ordered it poured.

KAI
No. It remembers what was done here.

His voice steadies.

KAI (CONT’D)
You’re not him.

The thing wearing Luther’s face goes still.

The wind stirs the trees at the far edge of the graveyard. Here, the air stays dead.

A distant BELL rings. Thin. Off-key.

LINA
Tell me that was a church bell.

EZRA
There hasn’t been service here in twenty years.

The figure steps back toward the trees. His outline smears at the edges.

KAI
What do you want?

The voice that answers carries Eli’s cadence and Luther’s pitch, layered together.

LUTHER
More.

He turns and fades into the tree line. Not into shadow. Into silence.

ROWAN
That wasn’t him.
Right?

Kai stares into the trees. Searching.

He doesn't answer.

Rowan looks down at his hands. At the ground.

ROWAN (CONT'D)
It keeps wearing the people you lost.
(beat)
And it keeps pointing at my last name.

A faint HOWL rises from somewhere beyond the ridge. Not quite animal. Not quite human.

They stand frozen.

CUT TO:

INT. EZRA'S TRUCK - MOVING - SUNSET

The truck barrels down a winding road. The last lights of town shrink in the rearview. Trees lean close like they're listening.

Inside, air held tight.

EZRA
Maybe we go to Rios. Or the mayor. Somebody.

KAI
And say what? That the ground's wrong and we made it worse?

ROWAN
Feels true.

Kai turns, eyes sharp.

KAI
He came to me. My family. If anyone has to face this, it's us.

A beat. Kai stares ahead.

KAI (CONT'D)
We need my grandmother. She knows more than anyone.

EZRA
Think she'll talk to us?

KAI
She keeps to herself. She'll talk to me.

LINA
I haven't seen her in years.

KAI
Lives out past the edge of everything. No landline. No visitors.

ROWAN
Sounds cozy.

Ezra's knuckles whiten on the wheel.

EZRA
So we tell her what? That something wearing Luther's face stepped out of the trees?

KAI
He was there. We all saw him.

ROWAN
We saw something.

LINA
And it saw us.

Lina's phone buzzes in her lap. "MARCUS HARJO" flashes on the cracked screen. She glances down, thumb hovering, steals a look at Kai's profile, then turns the screen face down.

The road narrows. Darkness thickens ahead like a wall.

Silence settles in. The engine hums into night.

CUT TO:

EXT. RIDGE LINE - NIGHT

Fog threads through skeletal trunks. Miles away, Beast Fest lights flutter like false stars against the dark.

Yellow police tape marks a perimeter. Patrol lights spin. Locals huddle behind squad cars, phones raised, recording.

Rios's TRUCK pulls up hard. He climbs out, already frayed.

INT. RIOS TRUCK - EARLIER

Parked on a forgotten service road. Leather creaks as he shifts.

His JOURNAL lies open on the passenger seat: a charcoal sketch of the STONE SYMBOL. Beneath it, in tight handwriting: “Neeka Blackdeer - remembers what happened at Mission Ridge.”

A POLAROID tucked in the flap: Neeka and Mary Blackdeer as teenagers, laughing, wind in their hair.

From the glovebox, he pulls an old SHERIFF’S BADGE. His father’s.

RIOS (V.O.)
My father covered the last mess.
I get the next one.

A TAP on the window. He flinches. RAMIREZ peers in.

RAMIREZ
Got a call. It’s bad. You need to see it.

RIOS
Where.

RAMIREZ
Ridge Line. Past the old orchard.
(beat)
It’s Marcus Harjo.

Rios’s stomach drops. He slams the glovebox, throws the truck in gear.

EXT. RIDGE LINE - BACK TO SCENE

Rios ducks under the tape. Ramirez follows. Their breath ghosts in the cold.

They reach the clearing.

MARCUS HARJO lies sprawled, body twisted, chest is open.

Rios sinks to his knees beside him. His hands shake.

RIOS
(soft)
Marcus...

RAMIREZ
Same mark. Same as the hill.

Rios closes his eyes for a beat.

RIOS
His grandmother, Ruth. Tribal Council.

RAMIREZ
Mayor Kinney will lose it.

Rios rises, gaze fixed on Marcus's face.

RIOS
Call it in. Keep it quiet. No press. No alerts.
(beat)
This festival ends tonight.

Ramirez's radio SQUAWKS. Mayor Kinney's voice bleeds through, tight.

MAYOR KINNEY (V.O.)
Detective Rios. Stand down. We will speak with the Harjos.
(beat)
No panic. Not tonight.
Not with the festival halfway through.

Rios looks at Marcus again.

RIOS
That kid died outside town lines.
That enough "no panic" for her.

RAMIREZ
You really think this is the same thing? From back then.

RIOS
Marcus's grandfather stood on that hill the night they covered it. Now his grandson's lying open in a ditch.
(beat)
This isn't random.
It's following the same families tied to that night.

Ramirez swallows.

RAMIREZ
You think it's going after them one by one.

RIOS
I think it started with mine.

He stares into the black line of woods.

RIOS (CONT'D)
Get more units across town. Plain clothes. I don't want a single kid walking alone.

RAMIREZ
Mayor said no extra patrols.

RIOS
Then they stay quiet. If we lose another kid, she can explain it to their parents.

Ramirez nods.

RIOS (CONT'D)
Find those four. Now.

RAMIREZ
Last ping on their phones was near the old graveyard.

RIOS
(grim)
Then we're late.

CUT TO:

INT. RIOS OFFICE - LATER THAT NIGHT

A single desk lamp glows. Walls layered with files, photos, maps. Red string webs between dates.

CLOSE ON: A photo of MARCUS HARJO pinned to the board. Smiling at a youth rally, mic in hand.

Rios writes in red marker: "HARJO FAMILY - TAKEN."

He tacks up photos of Kai, Rowan, Ezra, Lina. Circles each name.

He adds MAYOR KINNEY at a Beast Fest ribbon cutting, BEAST FEST - NIGHT TWO TONIGHT banner behind her.

RIOS
(under his breath)
It's still moving.
(MORE)

RIOS (CONT'D)
(beat)
And we're standing in the path.

The lamp flickers.

CUT TO:

EXT. MARY BLACKDEER'S HOUSE - NIGHT

A small ranch house at the edge of town. Porch light on. Warm windows spilling TV glow and kitchen light into the dark. Beyond, only trees.

Ezra's TRUCK rolls to a stop in the gravel drive. Engine cuts. The night presses in.

KAI
This is where she said to meet.

ROWAN
Feels like we're crashing family dinner.

They climb out, cross to the porch. From inside: low MUSIC from an old stereo, the murmur of a TV in another room, the faint CLINK of dishes.

Kai knocks.

A beat. The deadbolt clicks. The door opens.

INT. MARY BLACKDEER'S HOUSE - CONTINUOUS

A lived-in home. Open kitchen and living room. A modern fridge covered in magnets and school photos. A half-finished JIGSAW PUZZLE on the coffee table. A streaming menu paused on the TV. A SCENT of stew and bread in the air.

MARY BLACKDEER (60s) stands in the doorway in sweats and an oversized t-shirt, hair up, dish towel in hand. Tired, sharp-eyed.

Behind her, at the dining table, NEEKA BLACKDEER (80s) works clay between her fingers, small SCULPTURES lined up beside a mug of tea.

Mary takes them in. No surprise.

MARY
You look worse than my leftovers.

She steps aside.

MARY (CONT'D)
Shoes off. Then talk.

They toe off their shoes and step in. Ezra's eyes flick to the clay, the TV, the puzzle, like he didn't expect any of this to be so ordinary.

Mary shuts the door, throws the deadbolt, pulls the curtain across the window in one smooth motion.

NEEKA
They came. That counts.

The kids hover awkwardly between kitchen and living room. Kai stands closest to Neeka, shoulders coiled.

KAI
We saw him. Out at Mission Ridge.
(beat)
My grandfather.

Mary's expression tightens, then smooths. She moves to the stove, turns the simmering burner down.

MARY
People see who they miss when they walk on ground that never settled. Grief does its own work.

KAI
This wasn't grief.
(voice rough)
It knew things only he knew. Then it started talking like something else.

LINA
Felt like something wearing him. Like a copy that didn't care if we noticed.

Neeka studies Kai, then Lina, then the boys. She wipes her clay-streaked fingers on a dish towel and nods toward the table.

NEEKA
Sit.

INT. MARY BLACKDEER'S HOUSE - LATER

They crowd around the dining table. Clay figures — small animals, half-formed faces — watch from the edges.

Neeka stays standing, one hand on the back of a chair. Mary leans in the doorway between kitchen and living room, arms folded.

NEEKA
We're not medicine people. We don't carry songs for the Nation.
(beat)
We carry what we saw. And what we failed to say when it might've mattered.

She reaches under the table, pulls out a plain SHOEBOX, taped and retaped. Sets it down.

Inside: PHOTOCOPIED PAGES of the ledger, a folded, brittle LETTER, a narrow ROLL OF SURVEY TAPE, a coil of SILVER THREAD, a printed MAP with two spots circled: MISSION RIDGE and THE HOLLOW MOUND off of Bray Road.

No spectacle. Paper. Tape. String.

Neeka lifts the LETTER and hands it to Lina.

NEEKA (CONT'D)
Elijah Harjo wrote that after the first time he stood on a cut mound with your grandfather and Thundercloud's father. Nobody at City Hall wanted it in their files. So we kept it.

Lina unfolds it carefully. Reads under her breath, the words landing heavy.

LINA
He says the county cut a road through a mound near Bray.
(beat, eyes skimming)
They hit older graves. Pulled bones out with the dirt.

She swallows. The next line costs her.

LINA (CONT'D)
Says they told each other not to write that part down. So the town could sleep.

She looks up, eyes wet.

MARY
Those stories were meant for mouths. Not minutes.
(MORE)

MARY (CONT'D)
(beat)
Kids needed to know which hills you don't scrape flat for a shortcut.

Neeka nods at Lina.

NEEKA
So you hear it now. You remember. You pass it on different.

Lina grips the letter.

LINA
Why me.

MARY
Because you still hear the crack under the story.

Kai's thumb traces the circled marks on the MAP — one at Mission Ridge, one near Bray Road.

KAI
Ridge was the first wound.
Bray was the cut after.
(beat)
That's where it learned to travel on what people tried to hide.

Ezra leans in, eyes moving between the circles.

EZRA
So the Hollow isn't some new thing. It's the same line, kept open.

NEEKA
They linked wounds. Then walked away.

Rowan stares at the Bray circle, jaw tight.

ROWAN
Kinney poured that road. Our logo's in half the photos. That line on the letter — "Independent contractor, local firm." That's us.
(beat, to Kai and Lina)
You grew up hearing the mounds were anchors. We kept showing up with rebar and concrete.

No one rushes to soften it.

Neeka lifts the silver THREAD, lets it glint in the overhead light.

NEEKA
This came off a survey stake the day they pulled out of Bray. Someone wrapped it and mailed it with the letter. No return address.

She drops it on the map beside Bray Road.

NEEKA (CONT'D)
They called that a seal. It was a patch. You tore at it when you went back. That's not blame. That's description.

Ezra's voice is small.

EZRA
We thought we'd name it. Film it. Prove everyone wrong or right.
(beat)
Now it's starting again.

Mary pushes off the doorway, comes closer, fingers drumming on the table edge.

MARY
We let you grow up in a town that turned a wound into a mascot.
(beat)
You picked at a scar and didn't know it was there. That sits with us too.

Kai's mask cracks.

KAI
We didn't go there to hurt anyone. We wanted answers. For Eli.
(beat, the worry he hasn't said aloud)
Marcus hasn't answered since before we left town. We need him back in this story alive.

Ezra nods once, throat tight.

EZRA
We thought if it lived on a screen, it would make sense.

Rowan stares at the letter like it might catch fire.

ROWAN
I wanted to see what he saw that night. Before he vanished.
(beat)
Marcus was supposed to be with us tonight. Same families on that map. Same hill. Same mess my last name helped pour.

Neeka rests her palm flat on the table to steady it.

NEEKA
Listen to me.
(beat)
This thing isn't from our stories. Our people didn't call it here.

She taps the Bray circle.

NEEKA (CONT'D)
The church at Mission Ridge. The county survey. That road. Three Ho-Chunk men scared enough to go along.
(quiet)
They built something together when they cut through ancestral remains and lied about it.

Mary meets each kid's eyes in turn. Her voice stays plain.

MARY
People want to call it a spirit. A monster.
(beat)
Names make it feel clean. It isn't.

Ezra flinches, thinking of his footage.

EZRA
So what do we do. We go back out there and apologize to a hole in the ground?

Neeka's mouth tightens.

NEEKA
You don't beg it. You starve it.
(beat)
You put the names back. You say what happened where the town can't un-hear it.
(MORE)

NEEKA (CONT'D)
You stop selling the Beast and start telling the dead as people.

Lina takes that in, breath shaking.

LINA
We already went to the Ridge. The Mouth. It followed us. Wore Luther's face. Eli's voice.
(beat)
Feels like it has our number now.

MARY
It's been moving along that whole line for a long time. You're the first ones who walked straight into it knowing what it was.

Kai looks up at Neeka.

KAI
And if we can't.

Neeka looks toward the dark window, then back.

NEEKA
Then you won't be the only ones who remember you tried to stand in the way.
(beat)
And no one who survives gets to say "we didn't know" anymore.

Silence stretches. Refrigerator hum. Distant TV laugh track. Normal life pressing at the edges of something not normal at all.

Mary reaches for her PHONE on the counter, flips it screen-up: a WEATHER ALERT, a missed call from RIOS, texts stacking in from RUTH and TENAYA. She locks it, sets it face down.

MARY
You go back out there, you turn these off.

She taps Lina's phone on the table. Then Ezra's.

Both screens show low bars, NO SERVICE. Still awake. Still cameras.

MARY (CONT'D)
No posts. No photos in the graveyard. Some things don't need to see themselves on a screen.
(MORE)

MARY (CONT'D)
That's one less mirror for it to climb through.

Ezra nods, throat tight.

EZRA
Off. Got it.

Neeka pulls a folded CANVAS SATCHEL from the box, worn but sturdy. She tucks the photocopies, the map, the roll of survey tape, and the letter inside. Closes it. Hands it to Lina.

NEEKA
Carry this. Paper. Ink. Proof.
(beat)
Doesn't stop it. Means someone walked in carrying more than fear.

Lina hugs the satchel to her chest.

LINA
Feels heavy already.

NEEKA
Good. Weight keeps you from blowing away.

Mary looks at all four of them, softer now.

MARY
You step out that door, you walk as people who know the story. There's no going back to not knowing.
(beat)
So decide what you're willing to carry into that hill. And what you refuse to bury for it.

No one argues.

EXT. MARY BLACKDEER'S HOUSE - NIGHT

They step back into the cold. Porch light halos them. Beyond the yard, dark trees. Somewhere far off, the faint ghost of Beast Fest noise rides the wind — music, laughter, a distant cheer.

Fog curls low around their ankles.

Lina adjusts the satchel strap across her chest.

LINA
This isn’t a haunting. It’s a history.

ROWAN
And our names are on the page.

Kai looks toward the tree line. Toward where the Hollow waits.

KAI
Then we make sure it stops with us.

EZRA
I’m going to the garage. I gotta be alone for a bit.

ROWAN
You sure thats the right call.

EZRA
Yeah.

A beat.

KAI
Your truck.

Ezra looks at him, impatient, wrecked.

EZRA
I’ll drop you at your place. Don’t follow me right away.

LINA
We’re coming when we’re set.

Ezra gives a tight nod, already walking.

Lina threads her fingers through Kai’s for a moment. They all pile back into the truck.

Headlights flare on. Gravel crunches. The house shrinks in the rearview, warm windows fading behind them.

INT. MARY BLACKDEER’S HOUSE - CONTINUOUS

Mary stands at the window, watching the taillights disappear.

Neeka stacks the little clay figures in a neat line along the sill. People. Animals. One with a long, not-quite-wolf face turned toward the glass.

One LAMP stays on in the living room. The TV plays. Life continues.

From deep in the woods, a faint SCREAM rises and frays into the wind.

Neither woman flinches.

Mary reaches for the remote. Turns the TV volume down even further, until only their breathing fills the room.

CUT TO:

EXT. BRAY ROAD - NIGHT

A full moon, hazed by distant fireworks, edges the sky. A lonely stretch of two-lane blacktop snakes through the woods.

The low HUM of a big rig grows louder.

INT. SEMI TRUCK CAB - NIGHT

A tired DRIVER (40s) in a hi-vis jacket with a KINNEY & WATTS CONSTRUCTION patch crumples a gas station burrito wrapper. His CB RADIO crackles beside a smartphone mounted on the dash with a GPS map glowing.

DRIVER
(into CB)
Dispatch, this is Unit Seventeen. Something's on Bray past marker nineteen.
(beat)
Thought it was a deer. Too tall. Walking on two legs.

His headlights sweep over the road ahead.

The truck JOLTS.

EXT. BRAY ROAD - CONTINUOUS

The rig fishtails. Brakes SCREAM. A front tire BLOWS, shredding rubber. The truck grinds to a halt, half on, half off the asphalt.

Where it skids, the tires scrape across an older, rough strip of patched road — a long scar cutting the lane in two.

INT. SEMI TRUCK CAB - CONTINUOUS

The driver grips the wheel, breathing hard.

DRIVER
Come on...

He grabs a MAGLITE from the dash, kills the engine, and climbs down.

EXT. BRAY ROAD - NIGHT

Silence. No insects. No wind. The dark feels thick.

The driver sweeps the flashlight beam along the road.

Massive gouges score the asphalt, tearing across the old patch. Claw-like. Fresh.

Something wet and dark glistens on the bumper, steaming faintly in the cool air.

He crouches, squints.

DRIVER
That's not deer.

A faint SCUFF behind him. He whips the light around.

Nothing. Trees. Fog.

He backs toward the cab, pulse in his throat.

A dull THUD above. Metal flexes.

He tilts the beam up along the side of the trailer, toward the cab roof.

DRIVER (CONT'D)
No. No, no—

A huge shadow moves along the roofline. For a split second, something like a hand with too many joints presses the metal down.

The driver bolts for the door.

The roof caves inward with a scream of steel. The flashlight drops, beam spinning across the road.

His shout rips through the night, then cuts off mid-breath.

The truck rocks once. Twice. Then goes still.

The Maglite lies on the shoulder, beam pointed at the treeline.

CUT TO:

EXT. WOODS OFF BRAY ROAD - LATER

Police lights strobe red-blue across the trees. A second patrol car pulls in.

Rios steps out, closing his jacket. Deputy HENDERSON joins him.

HENDERSON
Tire blew. He radioed something on the road. We lost him three minutes later.

Rios approaches the rig, flashlight ready.

INT. SEMI TRUCK CAB - NIGHT

His beam reveals shredded upholstery. Blood smeared across the ceiling and driver’s seat. No body.

Rios takes in the empty space where someone should be.

He lowers the light, eyes moving back toward the dark line of trees.

Off his face, knowing it is the same pattern widening—

CUT TO:

EXT. TREE LINE - MOMENTS LATER

Rios follows a blood trail off the road. Something heavy was dragged.

He pushes through underbrush—

Stops.

A BODY hangs against a thick trunk, high off the ground. The driver’s shirt is shredded. Blood streaks the bark in vertical lines. One boot dangles, empty.

Rios keeps his beam tight, refusing the full picture.

HENDERSON (O.S.)
What the hell...

Rios turns. In the far distance, FIREWORKS bloom over the Beast Fest grounds, colors flaring against the night.

A sick kind of beauty.

RIOS
(quiet)
It’s not hiding anymore.

Off the blood on the bark, the mark in the dirt—

CUT TO:

INT. EZRA’S GARAGE - NIGHT

Wind rattles corrugated metal. A single bulb hums overhead.

Oil stains on concrete. Tools hang in rows.

Ezra sits on a workbench, shirt off. A bottle of whiskey sits half-empty beside him. His phone lies next to it, screen awake on a paused police scanner app.

He grips a rag, scrubbing at the raw symbol burned into his shoulder.

He hisses in pain, teeth clenched.

POLICE SCANNER (O.S.)
(static)
...Marcus Harjo... body recovered near the line... family notified...

Ezra freezes.

He stares at the screen, reading the words again and again.

He slams the phone face down. Kills the app.

Silence rushes in.

His hands tremble. He lifts a cracked mirror shard, angles it to see his shoulder.

The scar looks angry. Raised. The skin around it reddened like fresh burn.

EZRA
(hoarse)
No...

He hurls the bottle. It explodes against the wall. Glass skitters.

A KNOCK hits the metal door. He flinches.

KAI (O.S.)
Ezra. Open up.

EZRA
Go home.

ROWAN (O.S.)
We're not leaving you alone in there.

The door creaks open.

Kai, Rowan, and Lina step inside, flashlights cutting through the dim. Their faces look hollowed out.

They stop when they see him. Shirt off. Shoulder slick with blood around the mark.

LINA
Oh God...

ROWAN
What happened?

Ezra laughs once. It snaps into something closer to a sob.

EZRA
You really don't know.

They say nothing.

EZRA (CONT'D)
Marcus is gone.

He nods toward the police scanner.

EZRA (CONT'D)
Dispatch said they found him by the ridge. What was left.

The others lock up. Rowan's hand finds the nearest tool chest to steady himself.

Kai's breath stutters.

KAI
No. He wasn't even at the hill. He didn't—

EZRA
Doesn’t matter. He knew. Same as us.

LINA
Ezra, you—

EZRA
(sharp)
I heard it, Lina. He’s dead. And this-

He jabs a finger at his shoulder. The skin twitches under his touch.

EZRA (CONT’D)
This thing flared up before they even said his name out loud.

ROWAN
Let me see.

Ezra steps into the bulb’s circle of light. The mark pulses in time with his heartbeat, more angry than before.

Lina’s voice drops.

LINA
That looks worse than last time.

KAI
When did it start burning like that.

EZRA
After the church. I washed the dirt off. It came up through my skin like someone held a lighter to it from the inside.

KAI
You could have called.

EZRA
For what. So you could sketch it into your journal? Add me to your map of who the Hollow likes to chew on?

KAI
That’s not what I—

EZRA
You know it is.

He points at Kai.

EZRA (CONT'D)
You walk around like every bad thing is aiming for you on purpose. Like it makes the pain mean something if you're at the center.

ROWAN
Ezra—

EZRA
No. He needs to hear it.
(to Kai)
Your brother died and now you act like you're the only one carrying a ghost. We all lost people. We do not make a story out of it.

KAI
You think I want any of this? I hear Eli under dirt every night.

EZRA
Then why keep pulling the grave open.

Ezra shoves a tool cart. Wrenches and sockets clatter across the floor. One socket spins in a tight circle, then falls flat.

The bulb flickers. A low HUM rises in the walls.

LINA
Stop. All of you. You're feeding it.

ROWAN
She's right.
It chews on this. The fighting.

Ezra grips his shoulder. The skin looks hot, almost swollen. He groans.

EZRA
Make it stop. Please—

The mark throbs, darkening and lightening with his pulse.

KAI
Ezra—

Kai grabs Ezra's forearm. Contact.

A jolt hits both of them–

FLASH:

The ridge. The mound. Marcus's hand reaching out of the ditch, fingers coated in mud.

BACK TO:

Kai yanks his hand away. His wrist tingles where he touched Ezra.

LINA
Kai?

Kai stares at his arm. Nothing visible now. Fear stays.

Ezra sags against the wall, breathing shallow, tears bright.

EZRA
It's in everything. Every road, every yard, every lie they told to make this place look clean. It is not letting go.

KAI
(quiet)
We didn't wake it.

Ezra looks up.

KAI (CONT'D)
We pulled the cover off something that was already moving.

Beat.

Ezra stands with effort. He wipes his face with the back of his hand.

Then he swings, fist connecting with Kai's jaw.

KAI (CONT'D)
You—

Kai slams into him. They crash into the wall. Tools rain down. Fists land wild.

Lina lunges between them and gets shoved sideways. She catches herself on a workbench.

LINA
Stop! Both of you, stop!

Ezra's chest heaves. Kai's lip bleeds. Rage starts to drain, leaving rawness.

LINA (CONT'D)
You think Marcus wanted this?
You think Eli wanted this?

Silence drops heavy.

Ezra looks away.

EZRA
Get out.

KAI
Ezra—

EZRA
Go.
Before I say something
I cannot undo.

Lina grips Kai's arm. Pulls him toward the door. Rowan backs out with them, eyes still on Ezra.

ROWAN
(soft)
We're not done.
We're coming back.

The metal door thuds shut.

Ezra stands alone. The bulb stutters overhead.

The mark on his shoulder throbs like a warning light in the dark.

A faint scrape sounds behind a sheet of metal. Slow. Dragging. Nails or claws against steel.

Ezra turns toward it, every muscle tight.

EZRA
(low)
I didn't want it to go
this far.

The bulb POPS. Glass rains down. The garage drops into black.

CUT TO:

EXT. FIRE TOWER RIDGE - NIGHT

Wind moves through the trees. Moonlight cuts through thin clouds. Fireworks bloom far below where Beast Fest still rages. Red. White. Gold.

Up here, it feels like another world.

Kai's truck sits crooked near the old tower. Tailgate down.

Kai and Lina sit on blankets in the truck bed, wrapped in one larger blanket. Their clothes are rumpled. Their skin touches in small, quiet ways. Breath visible in the cold.

They wait in the stillness.

Kai stares toward the valley.

KAI
I didn't think it would feel like this.

LINA
Like what.

KAI
Like I'm still me.
Even with all of it.

She brushes hair off his forehead. He leans into her touch.

LINA
You are.

KAI
I feel marked.
Like something is waiting in the corner of my eye.

He shivers. She draws him closer.

LINA
Look at me.

He does. His eyes are rimmed red.

LINA (CONT'D)
That thing out there, whatever name it wears, does not get to tell you who you are. We do that for ourselves.

KAI
Feels late for that.

She rests her forehead against his. Their breath mixes in the cold.

LINA
You feel it
because you're still human.
That matters.

He breaks. Shoulders shake. The dam goes.

He sobs into her shoulder. Ugly, real.

She holds him without flinching.

KAI
I can't hold all of it. Eli.
Luther. Marcus. The hill. The town.
All of it.

LINA
Then let me hold some.

He looks at her. Every guard stripped.

KAI
This is my first time.

She quirks an eyebrow.

LINA Pretty sure you kissed someone once at Homecoming.

KAI (CONT'D)
Not that.
(beat)
This.
(beat)
Trusting someone this much.

She cups his face.

LINA
You're not alone.

She places her hand over his heart. Feels it.

He covers her hand with his.

They kiss. Slow. Careful. Needing connection more than anything else.

The blanket shifts around them, turning them into one bundled shape against the cold.

Fireworks burst behind them, unseen.

The forest stands around them. For a moment the Hollow cannot reach into the space they made.

EXT. FIRE TOWER RIDGE - LATER

They lie together under the same blanket. Their bodies tangled for warmth. Soft breath. The world feels far away.

Kai traces a line down Lina’s spine through the fabric.

KAI
Every time I close my eyes I see the hill. The mark. The way it looks at us without eyes.

LINA
Then we face it. Together.

KAI
You mean that.

LINA
I have never been clearer about anything.

He exhales. Some tension leaves him.

A HOWL slices the night. Wrong. Off.

Something learning how to sound alive.

They jerk upright.

LINA (CONT’D)
That’s not close. It is moving though.

KAI
Home feels like a target now.

LINA
My uncle’s cabin. Off Route eleven. No service. Solid locks. Food in the pantry.

Kai grabs his phone. His fingers move fast.

INSERT - PHONE SCREEN: TEXT TO “ROWAN”: Fire tower isn’t safe. Meet us at Lina’s uncle’s cabin. Code 1321.

KAI
Let’s go.

They pull on clothes, gather their things.

Lina glances up at the dark outline of the tower.

Wind moves through the metal. It sounds a little like something saying their names and a little like wood remembering storms.

They climb into the truck. Tail lights disappear down the ridge road.

CUT TO:

EXT. ELKHORN - OUTSKIRTS - NIGHT

Rowan walks alone, hands deep in his jacket, head down. Fireworks bloom over town. Laughter drifts thin, more echo than joy.

He slips past the last vendor tent. String lights fall behind him. Music fades. He steps into open dark.

Overhead, branches shift. A SHADOW glides between trunks, pace matching his.

Rowan glances back. Empty sidewalk. No one there.

He keeps moving, desperate to hold himself together.

EXT. SMALL TOWN STREET - NIGHT

Quieter streets. Closed shops. Porch lights off. The air feels colder out here.

Rowan passes a dark storefront. In the glass, a shape stands behind him.

He spins. Sidewalk empty.

Something in his face shifts. Recognition without proof.

Across the street, in a narrow alley, a figure. Hood up. Still. Watching. Eli.

Rowan steps off the curb.

ROWAN
Eli...

He reaches the alley.

Empty brick. Overflowing dumpster. No one.

His phone buzzes in his pocket. He checks the screen:

MISSED TEXTS from KAI: “Fire tower not safe. Call me.”

One from LINA: “Where are you?”

Rowan locks the screen without responding. His thumb hovers over Kai’s name, then drops.

EXT. HIGHWAY OUTSKIRTS - GAS STATION - NIGHT

A boarded-up GAS STATION sits under a dead neon sign. One tube flickers to life, then dies.

Rowan crosses the road, shoulders hunched. Wind threads through the busted pump canopy.

INT. GAS STATION - NIGHT

He ducks inside, phone flashlight cutting a narrow cone through dust. Bare shelves. Broken counter. Old snack wrappers ground into the floor.

He kicks aside debris. Something catches his eye.

A DUSTY POLAROID, pinned crooked to a corkboard.

CLOSE ON: Peewee football jerseys. Four kids mid-laugh. One is ELI. Helmet crooked, alive and weightless.

Rowan’s breath stutters. He reaches up, fingers brushing the photo.

The faint light overhead flickers once, then goes out for good. His phone screen dims to low power.

Silence shifts.

FOOTSTEPS in the back room.

Rowan freezes, breath held tight.

A quiet creak behind him. He turns his light.

Empty doorway.

He looks back to the entrance. The door stands open now, night spilling in like water.

Rowan pockets the phone and steps out toward the dark.

CUT TO:

EXT. HIGHWAY - LATER

Rowan walks the shoulder, thumb out. Dust clings to his jeans. His eyes look drained.

Headlights grow behind him, bright in the dark. An old pickup slows, engine rattling.

DRIVER (O.S.)
You look like hell, kid.

Rowan squints into the cab.

ROWAN
You headed east?

DRIVER (O.S.)
Sinclair Road off eleven. That's as far as I go.

Rowan nods, climbs in, pulls the door shut.

INT. TRUCK - MOVING - NIGHT

Old country radio mumbles under static. The driver chews gum, gaze locked on the road. A cracked smartphone glows in the dash mount, map pin crawling across back roads.

Rowan watches the window.

Dark trees blur by. For a split second, one trunk holds a FACE in the bark, eyes set where knots should be.

He blinks. Only branches.

The truck crests a hill.

Below, a heavy line of woods. The moon fights through cloud.

ROWAN (V.O.)
I thought grief would fade. That time sands it down. It doesn't. It turns into a road you keep walking on.
(beat)
Our road. Our name on it. A place that never lets you pass.

The truck turns down an old dirt spur.

CUT TO:

EXT. BACKROAD - NIGHT

A narrow dirt road threads between black trees.

KAI'S TRUCK rumbles past a faded sign: PRIVATE - NO TRESPASSING.

INT. KAI'S TRUCK - CONTINUOUS

Kai drives. Lina leans her forehead to the window, watching shadow patterns slide over the glass.

Tension sits between them from the garage, from the ridge, from everything.

KAI
You sure this place is safe.

LINA
My uncle stopped coming up after the fire. It was our hideout forever. No one pays attention to this road.

KAI
Feels like it slipped off a map.

EXT. CABIN - NIGHT

A small weather-worn cabin crouches in the trees. Paint gone to gray. One gutter hangs loose.

Kai and Lina step out, flashlights sweeping across the porch.

No porch light. No power hum. Wind moves through the branches.

LINA
Generator's dead. There's candles inside.

She checks her phone. "NO SERVICE." She tucks it away.

INT. CABIN - MOMENTS LATER

Rustic interior. Old hunting trophies on one wall. A Ho-Chunk quilt folded on a cedar chest. Shelves hold family photos, coffee mugs, and a dusty radio tucked beside paperbacks.

Kai lights a candle on the table. Flame wavers, then steadies.

LINA (O.S.)
Look at this.

She stands by a bookshelf, holding up a faded photo.

In the picture: her UNCLE, younger, arm slung around ELIJAH HARJO. RIOS' FATHER stands behind them, hand on Elijah's shoulder. A TEEN NEEKA BLACKDEER lingers at the edge, half-smile, all watchful.

KAI
That's Elijah.

LINA
And that's Rios' dad.

She digs into a cardboard box on the floor. Old snapshots: TRIBAL GATHERINGS, FUNDRAISERS, FUNERALS. Kids standing near a low hill of earth that matches the Hollow's shape.

KAI
They all knew that place.

Kai opens a lower drawer. Finds a narrow ledger, cover cracked.

He lifts it to the candlelight. Inside: names, dates, locations. Notes in English and in Ho-Chunk. Lines crossed out hard enough to tear the page.

One entry is circled in red ink: WE DIDN'T SEAL IT. WE SURRENDERED.

Kai reads, voice low.

KAI (CONT'D)
This wasn't a spellbook. It's an apology.

Next to a list of FLOODS and CAR WRECKS: clumsy CHARCOAL SKETCHES of the Beast, never full, always half off the page. Margins crowded with corrections, arrows, crossed-out theories.

Kai shuts the ledger with care.

Lina pulls off her jacket, sets it on a chair. She remembers something, reaches into her bag.

She brings out the SATCHEL from Mary's house — canvas, scuffed, ordinary.

She opens it.

Inside: the folded LETTER from Elijah, the rough CARVED TOKEN on its thin cord, and the simple cloth wrap Mary used to carry them.

Lina lays them on the table like evidence.

LINA
He wrote it all down.

Kai unfolds the letter. Reads. His throat tightens.

KAI
They didn't hand us a monster story.
(beat)
They handed us what they hid.

Lina nods once, eyes on the token.

LINA
So that's the rule. No more pretending we don't see it.

The candle POPS softly.

Outside, the treeline shivers once. The cabin does not.

CUT TO:

INT. TOWN HALL - NIGHT

Fluorescents off. Lamps and half-burned candles throw pockets of gold across scuffed linoleum. Old folding chairs line the walls like tired witnesses. Framed photos of ribbon-cuttings and Beast Fest parades stare down from crooked angles.

A faded Wisconsin flag droops in one corner; an "ELKHORN PROUD" banner hangs beside a fire alarm with duct tape over the test switch. The air feels stale, thick with years of arguments soaked into wood and paint.

Rios stands at the front, worn and wired, palms pressed to a carved table.

Around him sit:

- COUNCILWOMAN TENAYA (60s), composed, spine like iron. - RUTH HARJO (70s), grief-stripped, eyes raw.

- Several TRIBAL ELDERS, listening more than speaking.

In the center of the table: an old photo. The Hollow in the background.

A young Elijah Harjo, Lina's uncle, Luther and Neeka Blackdeer, Rowan's grandfather, Rios' father, and others.

RIOS
We have a second body. Long-haul driver, Bray Road. Same damage.

RUTH
Like Marcus. Say his name.

Silence. No one breathes.

RUTH (CONT'D)
He was sixteen. He still had turf on his cleats from Friday. We sat in this room and kept the same story bolted down over that hill.

TENAYA
Ruth—

RUTH
Do not soften it. This is my family.

She slams her palm on the photo.

RUTH (CONT'D) (CONT'D)
And theirs. You remember what we agreed to. What we watched happen. How many times we called it something else.

ELDER #1
We honored what we said we would do. We kept the town steady through relocation. Through the highway cut.

RUTH
We told ourselves losing some was the price of keeping most alive. That is not peace. That is betting with kids.

RIOS
My father never told me it was like this. He said there was a cost. That it stayed with him.

TENAYA
He thought hiding it from you would spare you. So did I. We fed silence instead of facing it.

ELDER #2
We told ourselves our job was to keep it from spreading. Not tear the whole town apart.

RUTH
Marcus is dead.
Kept from spreading for who.

She breaks. Tears hit the photo. She covers her face, sound torn from somewhere deep.

Rios swallows hard.

RIOS
So what now. We stand here and wait. Hope it runs out of names.

TENAYA
We cannot shut down Beast Fest.

Rios stares at her.

RIOS
Kids are getting torn apart and you want the lights on.

TENAYA
Crowds make fear loud. Loud fear gets reckless. We trigger panic, bodies hit the ground for reasons that have nothing to do with the Hollow. Then everyone points here.

RUTH
Still choosing quiet over truth. Same as the ones smiling in that picture.

Tenaya stands, hands flat on the table.

TENAYA
I am choosing survival.
(beat)
We bought a fragile calm with silence and half-truths. That trade ends now.

She looks to Rios.

TENAYA (CONT'D)
Those kids are already walking closer to it than we can. They might be the ones who cut through what our generation tied up.

RUTH
So we send them in.

TENAYA
We give them what we refused them. Memory. Time. A chance to choose for themselves.

Rios nods once.

RIOS
What do you need from me.

Tenaya steps to a small locked cabinet. Unlocks it. Inside, a weathered ledger bound tight.

She sets it on the table.

TENAYA
Find Mary Blackdeer.
She was there when this record was made. She knows where the line cracked first.

Ruth lifts her head. Eyes red, voice low.

RUTH
Tell her Marcus didn't vanish into a blank.
(beat)
Tell her we said his name in here.

Rios nods. The choice settles on his shoulders.

He takes the ledger.

CUT TO:

EXT. MARY BLACKDEER'S PROPERTY - LATER

Wind cuts through birch trunks. A porch lantern fights the dark, its flame small yet stubborn.

Rios steps from his cruiser. The night presses in from every side.

He climbs the steps and knocks.

A long pause.

The door opens. MARY BLACKDEER stands in the frame, bone-thin, eyes sharp and tired.

MARY
Neeka's out in the holler. Sunrise at the earliest.

RIOS
I came for you.

She studies his face. Her expression falls a notch.

MARY
It's walking again.

She steps aside.

INT. MARY BLACKDEER'S CABIN - NIGHT

Warmth holds in the corners. A small place built for quiet.

A single lamp throws soft light over a worn couch. A quilt lies folded at one end, used more than displayed. The TV sits on a low stand with the streaming menu paused, volume off. A router blinks beside a stack of unopened mail and a weekly pill organizer. In the kitchen, a kettle rides low heat, not quite singing yet. A radio murmurs somewhere back in the house. Coffee and baked bread hang in the air.

The front door shuts behind Rios. Road dust on his boots, storm in his eyes.

At the table, he sets down a CRACKED LEDGER bound in worn leather.

The router blinks once… stutters… then goes steady again.

Mary stops in the doorway. Color drains from her face.

MARY
Where did that come from.

RIOS
Tenaya handed it to me. Said you would know.

Mary steps closer. She looks at the ledger like it might bite. Her hand hovers, then pulls back.

MARY
They swore it would stay sealed. Not since the night everyone in that picture chose their side.

RIOS
What is it.

Mary forces herself to touch the cover. Fingers trace the cracks.

MARY
A record. First bodies. First land they gave up. Every time the county called it an accident. Every time the church asked for patience. Every time our own signed their names and told themselves it was mercy.

RIOS
So it maps what they did.

MARY
It admits what they did. That is why they feared it.

Rios exhales, tired to the bone.

RIOS
Two dead in one day. Marcus. A trucker on Bray. Torn apart.

Mary closes her eyes. She grips the table.

MARY
The wind turned cold this afternoon.
(beat)
Felt sharp in my lungs. The land started screaming again.

She crosses to the mantle, picks up a framed photo: KAI, MARCUS, ROWAN in their football uniforms, arms over shoulders. All smiling. All alive.

MARY (CONT'D)
You think this is new. A glitch.

She looks at Rios.

MARY (CONT'D)
We have lived with this shadow since before your father put on a badge.

RIOS
The elders told me it was sealed decades ago.

MARY
Sealed with silence.

Her voice hardens.

MARY (CONT'D)
Your father. Luther Blackdeer. Elijah Harjo. They stood on that hill and chose silence.
(beat)
Called it balance. Called it mercy.

Mary SLAMS the photo down. It skids to the edge of the table.

Rios hesitates, then picks it up. Slips it into his coat like it might break.

MARY (CONT'D)
Mercy for who.

She looks at him, raw.

MARY (CONT'D)
You were there when they pulled Eli out. You remember his face.

Rios flinches. Haunted.

MARY (CONT'D)
He was my first grandson. This never ended, Rios. It only went quiet enough for people to sleep.

RIOS
We wanted to believe it was finished.

MARY
You hoped distance and time would do the work you refused to do.

She taps the ledger.

MARY (CONT'D)
That thing is every choice written down.

Rios looks hollowed out.

RIOS
People keep calling it a spirit. A monster. Is that what it is.

Mary's answer is sharp, grounded.

MARY
If it were one of our old stories, we would have a name older than the highway.
(beat)
This thing is not Ho-Chunk. Our people did not call it here.

She steps closer. to the ledger, hand resting on it now.

MARY (CONT'D)
The county, the church, that road, and three of ours scared enough to stand there with them.

Resting her hand on the ledger.

MARY (CONT'D)
It lives in the gaps. Paved graves. Lost files. All the Beast Fest jokes where no one says who died for the story. That is what it eats.

RIOS
So what does it want. More.

MARY
More empty. More places where the story cuts off and everyone nods like that is the end.

RIOS
My father took his badge out there once. Set it down on the mound. Said he wanted the past to feel the weight he carried. That was his story.

Rios swallows.

RIOS (CONT'D)
Then how do we hit it.
Practically.

Mary studies him for a long beat. Decides he is ready, or close enough.

MARY
You do not stab it, Rios. You starve it.
(beat)
You put the names back. You say what happened out loud where the town cannot un-hear it.
You stop selling the Beast and start telling the dead as people.

She leans on the table, eyes never leaving his.

MARY (CONT'D)
It feeds on what everybody agrees to forget. So you do not forget.
Not once. Not in public.

The kettle gives a thin, sudden WHISTLE. Mary doesn't flinch. Rios does.

She turns it off without looking away.

Rios takes that in, shaken.

RIOS
The council wants answers.

MARY
Good. I have one.

She unrolls the ledger. Pages like river veins: dates, names, notes in English and Ho-Chunk, sketches of ROADS and FENCES and a crude outline of THE HOLLOW.

Her finger traces a line from a drawn MOUND to a penciled ROAD CUT.

MARY (CONT'D)
It was born when those developers cut into that mound and paved over graves.
(beat)
It grew every time our three agreed to bury the truth for them.

She points at the page.

MARY (CONT'D)
People died to keep this wound hidden. People died when it started walking through the cracks they left. It ends when somebody from each side walks into that place with nothing hidden. No kids sent ahead. No secrets left at home.

RIOS
And me.

MARY
You go in first. Badge and name on the line.

She turns the ledger toward him.

MARY (CONT'D)
Tomorrow, you carry this into that hall. You let them hear what really happened.You put the county, the church, and our own on the record.

A beat.

MARY (CONT'D)
Then you help those kids put the bones and the stories back where they belong.

Silence. The WIFI router blinks in the corner. The kettle clicks off. Ordinary sounds under something old and sharp.

RIOS
And if I cannot hold that line.

Her gaze slides past him, out the window to the dark tree line.

MARY
Then the Hollow remembers you as one more name that tried to walk around it.

Rios lifts the ledger. The weight of paper feels like stone.

He steps to the door. Opens it.

Cold night air knifes in.

EXT. MARY BLACKDEER'S CABIN - CONTINUOUS

Rios steps onto the porch, ledger under his arm, photo inside his coat.

Behind him, the porch lantern gutters, then steadies.

From deep in the trees, a HOWL rises. Long. Empty.

Rios faces the dark.

Then heads for his car.

CUT TO:

EXT. CABIN - NIGHT

The forest presses in, black, breathless. Lantern glow leaks from the cracks of Lina's uncle's hideout. Wind drags low over the trees.

Rowan staggers up the steps. Mud-caked. Eyes raw and sanded down. He punches in the door code. The lock clicks.

INT. CABIN - CONTINUOUS

Candlelight flickers. Kai and Lina turn fast. Exhaustion carved deep. Fear deeper.

ROWAN
Didn't say you were hosting the end of the world.

KAI
You made it.

ROWAN
Barely. Caught a ride with a prepper who thinks FEMA runs a lizard army.

He drops his bag. Silence settles.

Rowan clocks their faces. The map on the floor. The satchel open.

ROWAN (CONT'D)
Where's Ezra?

Lina's face answers before she speaks.

LINA
Gone. Since the fight.
We checked his place after we
texted you. No truck.
No Ezra. No note.

Rowan swallows hard, steadies himself on the doorframe.

ROWAN
You think it took him?

KAI
If it hasn't, it's reaching.

Wind claws at the cabin walls. A low moan trembles through the glass.

Lina kneels beside the satchel Mary gave her. She unwraps the cloth, revealing a small spread of familiar objects:

— ELIJAH HARJO'S LETTER, folded soft from hands.

— THREE SMALL CARVED TOKENS, rough and worn, matching the ones on their cords.

— A LENGTH OF SILVER THREAD, simple, unadorned, wound the way Mary wrapped it.

Nothing fancy. Nothing staged. The kind of things people keep when they have no other place to put the truth.

Rowan stares at them.

ROWAN
Feels like we walked into someone
else's confession.

LINA
Then we finish it. Starting with
Ezra.

Kai unrolls the hand-drawn MAP across the floor.

KAI
If he ran, he ran toward Bray.
Toward the Hollow.

ROWAN
Alone.

LINA
Not for long.

ROWAN
Not again.

The floor gives a deep, dull THRUM beneath them.

Dust lifts. Then settles.

A slow beat.

Another THRUM. Closer to the ribs.

LINA
(quiet)
It’s close.

Kai digs in his coat. Rios Thundercloud’s card appears, creased and damp.

LINA (CONT’D)
Landline’s in the kitchen. Cell’s useless out here.

He hurries down the short hallway.

INT. CABIN - KITCHEN - CONTINUOUS

A rotary phone hangs crooked on the wall. Kai dials fast with shaking fingers.

RIOS (V.O.)
Thundercloud.

KAI
It’s Kai. Lina’s uncle’s cabin off Route Eleven, past the old quarry. Ezra’s missing. Something’s moving under us—

A howl rips through the line. Inhuman. Wrong.

Static surges. Then dead quiet.

RIOS (V.O.)
(distorted)
Listen. Stay inside. Lock every window. No one goes to the glass. No splitting up. I’m coming. Keep away from the Hollow.

The line dies. Dial tone never returns. Kai hangs up.

INT. CABIN - MAIN ROOM - CONTINUOUS

ROWAN
That sounded bad.

KAI
He’s on his way. The rest is on us.

LINA
Then we hold.
(beat)
We wait. We fight. Together.

They sit in a triangle on the floor, the map and objects between them like a briefing table.

Rowan pulls out his phone on reflex. No bars. Battery at one percent.

He locks the screen and shoves it in his pocket.

ROWAN
One of us might not come back.

LINA
Then it stops with us.
Not the kids after.

Kai takes the silver thread from the satchel and ties it around his wrist. A wordless vow.

Rowan and Lina knot their own lengths beside his.

THRUM.

Again.

Faster now. The cabin answering a heartbeat that is not theirs.

Off their faces: young, terrified, braver than they should ever need to be.

EXT. HIGHWAY SHOULDER - NIGHT

Rios floors the cruiser through fog. Headlights burn without sirens. The radio hisses with half-heard calls.

His eyes lock on the dark line of trees ahead.

The road curves toward Bray Road and the blacker shadow of the Hollow.

EXT. BRAY ROAD - NIGHT

Wind tears through open fields. The moon hangs swollen and white behind haze.

Ezra stumbles along the gravel shoulder, his truck parked crooked behind him. Each breath cuts.

Ahead: tree line. The faint shape of the mound beyond.

He stops. Looks back toward the empty road, then toward the woods.

A low hum rises under the wind. Ancient. Hungry. Inside his bones.

EZRA
(whisper)
I hear you.

He steps off the asphalt.

EXT. THE WOODS / HOLLOW - CONTINUOUS

Branches claw at his jacket as he pushes through. The air thickens, heavy with damp soil and rust.

A clearing opens. The Hollow mound. Torn. Sunken. A scar in the earth.

Ezra drops to his knees at the edge. Hands trembling.

He reaches into his jacket and pulls out his CAMERA RIG — cracked phone mount, mic clipped on, dirt in the grooves. The thing he used to chase a story.

EZRA
You keep taking from us.

He presses the rig into the dirt at the lip of the Hollow.

The soil shivers.

His shoulder flares under his shirt, the mark burning like a brand waking up.

Ezra gasps, gripping the fabric.

ELI (V.O.)
You shouldn’t have come.

EZRA
You kept calling. I couldn’t stay away.

ELI (V.O.)
I didn’t. It did.

The ground under his knees pulses in time with his heartbeat. Steam coils up, iron-scented.

Inside the Hollow, something stirs. Shadow against deeper shadow. Bone-hinted. Fur-hinted. Impossible to pin down. A shape memory will never fully hold.

Ezra’s eyes brim.

EZRA
(whispers)
I see you.

A presence leans close, felt more than seen. Air turns cold as grave winter.

Soil inches from his face tears in four long gouges.

EZRA (CONT’D)
You got what you wanted from Eli. From Marcus. From the ones before.
(beat)
You do not get them. You take me.

Silence stretches. The hum drops to a low murmur.

His shoulder mark burns hotter, veins spidering out, then pulling back.

The camera rig sinks deeper into the earth, disappearing like an ember swallowed by ash.

The presence inhales, slow, like the land memorizing his shape.

Then it sinks away, down into the rupture.

Ezra collapses forward, catches himself with shaking hands. The mark still glows faintly under his shirt, like a warning light that never quite shuts off.

EZRA (CONT’D)
(hoarse)
I’m here.

Wind shifts, carrying the Hollow’s breath out toward town.

EXT. BACK ROAD - NIGHT

Gravel crunches under Rios's tires. The cruiser threads between leaning pines.

INT. CRUISER - MOVING - NIGHT

Rios drives like every second is slipping away.

On the passenger seat: a rolled bundle of yellowed maps and handwritten pages, rubber-banded, along with Mary's photo of Kai, Marcus, and Rowan in their football jerseys.

His phone, screen up, shows Kai's caller ID from a minute ago.

RIOS
(low, to himself)
Hold on.

He presses harder on the gas.

EXT. CABIN - NIGHT

Lantern glow breathes through the windows. Shadows move inside.

The cruiser skids to a stop. Rios climbs out, grabs the rolled bundle of records, checks his sidearm out of habit, then heads for the door.

He knocks once, hard.

INT. CABIN - NIGHT

The kids flinch at the pounding. Kai moves fast, unties the latch, opens the door.

Rios pushes in, damp with sweat and mist.

RIOS
No more opening that door. We move as one.

KAI
We thought maybe you—

RIOS
Ezra ran. He ran toward Bray. Our window is short.

He drops the bundled RECORDS on the table. The air shifts. Rowan and Lina step nearer.

ROWAN
What is all that?

RIOS
Names. Roads. The parts they locked away. Every time they chose quiet over truth.

Lina glances at Kai — it matches what they saw in the cabin ledger.

LINA
We have things too. From Mary. From Neeka.

She opens MARY'S SATCHEL.

Inside: ELIJAH HARJO'S LETTER, folded soft from hands, and a LENGTH OF SILVER THREAD, plain and unadorned, wound the way Mary wrapped it.

Nothing staged. The kind of things people keep when truth has nowhere else to go.

Rios takes it in. No ceremony. Only weight.

Kai sets their LEDGER beside the RECORDS. Two halves of the same wound meeting on one table.

KAI
We found their list. People it took. Times they called it anything except what it was.

ROWAN
Your dad. My grandpa. Elijah.

They were all there.

Rios swallows. Holds their eyes.

RIOS
Mary said they thought silence would hold the line.

It never did.

A deep THRUM rolls under the floor. Dust lifts, settles.

LINA
Then we stop giving it new gaps.
Ezra doesn't become another name no one finishes.

She taps the stack of RECORDS, the LEDGER, the satchel.

LINA (CONT'D)
We take what they hid, we take what we were given, and we stand on that hill where it can't look away.

ROWAN
If it's already reaching for Ezra—

LINA
He's alone. Like Eli. Like Marcus.

Rowan shakes his head hard.

ROWAN
Not again.

RIOS
We don't close every crack tonight.
(beat)
We stop feeding it with silence.

A beat. The three teens hold that.

ROWAN
Even if not all of us walk away?

Rios doesn't blink.

RIOS
We choose what fear takes.
Either more kids vanish into that dark or this thing hits a wall that stays standing.

The choice settles over them.

KAI
We find Ezra. We face the Hollow.
No more running.
No more pretending.

Rios gathers the RECORDS and the LEDGER, tucks them under his arm.

RIOS
And when we make it out, we tell it.
(MORE)

RIOS (CONT'D)
In that hall. In town. On paper. On camera. No more giving it quiet.

They all rise.

EXT. CABIN - NIGHT

They spill into the cold. Lantern glow at their backs, forest ahead.

For a moment they are silhouettes — small, outnumbered, choosing anyway.

They head toward the trees.

Toward the Hollow.

CUT TO:

EXT. WOODS - NIGHT

The cruiser barrels down a forgotten service road, roots cracking the asphalt, branches clawing the roof. Headlights slice through mist.

INT. CRUISER - CONTINUOUS

Rios drives. Rowan rides shotgun. Lina and Kai in the back, hunched over the letter and thread.

KAI
There. That clearing.

EXT. HOLLOW CLEARING - MOMENTS LATER

The cruiser skids to a stop. They pile out.

The Hollow rises before them, vast, ancient. A wound in the land. The dirt churned, gaping. Like something clawed its way out.

LINA
That wasn't like that before.

They move closer, each step heavier.

EZRA (O.S.)
(quiet, distant)
You came.

They turn.

Ezra stands at the mound's edge. Eyes sunken. Shirt torn. The mark on his shoulder glows faintly under his skin.

ROWAN
Ezra—

EZRA
It called me. Same way it called Eli.

Lina steps closer, careful.

LINA
What did it do?

EZRA
Didn't talk. Just… showed me.
What it remembers. What it wants.

KAI
And what's that?

EZRA
For the truth to hurt out here
the way it hurts in town.
(touches his chest)
No more Beast Fest. No more jokes.
Only what happened.

Rios steps forward, records tight against him.

RIOS
We brought what they left behind.
Notes. Names. The pieces they hid.
(beat)
We're not here to feed it.
We're here to face it.

Ezra looks down at his glowing mark.

EZRA
Then you'll need me.

ROWAN
You sure?

EZRA
I'm already tied to it.

The earth breathes. Deep. Rhythmic. Alive.

RIOS
Stay close. Whatever shows up, we stay together. No running. No breaking.

They move as one toward the mouth of the Hollow.

CUT TO:

EXT. HOLLOW MOUND - LATER

Moonlight bleeds through the trees as they fall away like teeth around an open maw. Mist hovers low, breathing across the ground.

The kids stand at the edge. KAI, LINA, ROWAN, EZRA. Fear welded to resolve. RIOS behind them, his father's BADGE in hand.

On the ground before them, the items they carried here:

- The brittle LETTER in Lina's hands.

- A coil of SILVER THREAD.

- PHOTOCOPIED LEDGER PAGES, corners soft from being held.

- A strip of SURVEY TAPE, faded orange, dirt-stained.

- The PHOTO from Mary's mantle.

ROWAN
I brought this too.

He places a FRAYED FRIENDSHIP BRACELET in the middle. Eli's.

A beat. The bracelet feels louder than any speech.

LINA
It started here.

KAI
Then it listens from here.

Ezra's MARK pulses faintly beneath his shirt, a soft red glow under skin that looks tired to hold it.

EZRA
(weak, shaking)
If it takes me… don't let it turn me into a story they sell.

RIOS
Whatever happens… we don’t break.
That’s how it got them alone.

Kai takes the SILVER THREAD, knots it around his wrist. Then Rowan’s. Then Lina’s. Then Ezra’s. Four points bound. Rios outside the line, watching, steady.

The silence is immense. Not still — listening.

Lina kneels at the lip of the Hollow. Her hands tremble around the LETTER.

She looks at the mound like it’s a throat that swallowed people.

LINA
I’m reading it.

Kai starts to speak, stops. He understands what this costs.

Lina unfolds the LETTER carefully. The paper crackles.

She reads out loud. Not a performance. A witness.

LINA (CONT’D)
“Elijah Harjo. County cut through the mound on Bray. They hit older graves. Bones came up with the dirt. They poured fill over what they could. Concrete over what they could not.”

Her voice tightens. She makes herself keep going.

LINA (CONT’D)
“They said it was progress. They called it a road. We stood there and let it be called that. We signed. We kept quiet. We told ourselves quiet was mercy.”

The air around them changes. Temperature drops through their coats, into their ribs. A LOW HUM rises from below — old, aching, hungry in a way that feels built, not born.

The Hollow’s center DARKENS. Soil shivers. Not a clean opening. A slow collapse, like the land giving up a breath it never wanted to hold.

VISIONS slam through them —

FLASHES:

- Hands signing papers as a bulldozer waits near a mound.

- A road crew laughing over lunch, earth piled high behind them.

- A badge dropped into mud streaked dark.

- MARCUS under stadium lights, laughing, whole.

- ELI'S fingers reaching up through soil, then letting go.

- A church bell ringing while a fence goes up.

BACK TO:

The HUM becomes pressure. A MASS at the edge of their circle. Height implied, not framed. A presence memory cannot hold.

Lina's eyes pour tears. Not fear. Grief that has nowhere to go.

She looks at each of them.

LINA (CONT'D)
I'm saying them.

She turns back to the mound. Her voice steadies on purpose.

LINA (CONT'D)
Eli Runningdeer.

The HUM flexes, like something hearing its first true name in years.

LINA (CONT'D)
Marcus Harjo.

Another pulse under their feet. Dirt lifts, settles.

LINA (CONT'D)
The trucker on Bray.

She swallows. Forces the last part through.

LINA (CONT'D)
And the ones before them. The ones nobody wrote down. The ones buried under the road.

Rowan steps closer to the edge. His throat works. He speaks into the pressure.

ROWAN
Kinney poured that road. My family signed those papers.
(beat)
I'm sorry. I'm not carrying that quiet anymore.

The presence leans in. Breath like winter graves on their faces.

Ezra's MARK flares. He drops to his knees.

EZRA
Take it from me, then. All of it.
(beat)
Leave them out of it.

The thread pulls taut between them. Four wrists bound. Four hearts refusing to split.

Rios steps forward. Lifts his father's BADGE. The metal is warped, dulled with thumbprints, lived with.

RIOS
He tried to pay with silence.

Rios tosses the badge into the circle. It lands in the ash and dirt, glinting once.

RIOS (CONT'D)
I'm not.

The unseen mass turns toward him. The HUM spikes, then fractures into overlapping WHISPERS — kids' voices, elders, prayers, screams. A town speaking through a mouth it never meant to build.

ROWAN
(through gritted teeth)
Stay with it. Don't look away.

Lina takes the LETTER, folds it once, like closing a wound with her own hands.

She lays it into the soil at the lip of the Hollow. Presses it down with her palm.

LINA
For Eli. For Marcus. For every name we finish tonight.

The pressure peaks — then breaks.

The HUM drops to a low THRUM, like a heartbeat through stone.

The soil in the Hollow slowly RISES, filling the sunken wound. Clods knit together. Roots re-settle. No explosion. No light. The land settling into a shape it remembers.

The silver thread chars and SNAPS. Their wrists sting where it touched.

Lina slumps. Kai catches her. Rowan drops to his knees, gasping. Ezra shudders, clutching his shoulder.

The glow beneath Ezra's skin fades to a faint scar.

Rios stands, chest heaving, eyes on the mound like he's waiting for it to speak again.

Silence.

EXT. HOLLOW MOUND - DAWN

Mist curls low. Pale light threads through the trees.

The survivors stand together: Kai, Lina, Rowan, Ezra, Rios. Silhouetted against the soft dawn.

The Hollow is no longer a gaping wound. A low mound again. Scarred. Uneven. Quiet.

ROWAN
(low)
Did we… do anything?

KAI
I don't hear it shouting.

LINA
I still feel it.

EZRA
(quiet)
Like a bruise you forget… until you touch it.

RIOS
Then remember where it hurts.

He looks at them — each of them.

RIOS (CONT'D)
That's how we keep it from owning the story again.

A beat in the new quiet.

Kai slides the scorched silver thread off his wrist. Frayed in his fingers. He lets it go. The wind takes it.

Together, they turn away. Not toward town. Forward.

The sun climbs higher. Behind them, the mound holds.

Deep in the soil, a faint THRUM lingers. Not a threat. A reminder.

CUT TO:

EXT. FOREST EDGE - ONE WEEK LATER - DUSK

A golden hush blankets the clearing. Trees lean in gently. The last light of day threads through smoke and candle flame.

A VIGIL.

Dozens of small candles flicker in a rough spiral around a low earthen mound built by hand. Stones, photographs, bits of thread. At its center: a photo of the TRUCKER, and a POLAROID of ELI and MARCUS, smudged but smiling.

A SMALL FOLDING TABLE sits just beyond the spiral. On it:

- THE LEDGER, spread open, pages weighted with cedar and river rock.

- PHOTOCOPIED PAGES in a neat stack, handwritten names and dates visible.

- A simple hand-lettered sign: WE SAY THEIR NAMES.

- A folded LOCAL NEWSPAPER. Half-visible headline: “BEAST FEST HALTED AS COMMUNITY NAMES ITS DEAD.”

Ruth lights three candles. One for each life taken. Her hands shake, yet stay steady enough.

Mary stands with Neeka beside her. Shawls wrapped tight. Present. Unbowed.

TEENS and ELDERS form a circle. No stage. No microphones. Generations shoulder to shoulder.

Kai sits at the spiral’s edge, sketchbook on his knee. Pencil tracing the memorial mound — whole, scarred, held.

Lina watches him. She laces her fingers with his. A quiet vow.

Rowan and Ezra step forward. Rowan lays down ELI'S OLD FRIENDSHIP BRACELET. Ezra sets his CRACKED VIDEO CAMERA beside it. Stories that once chased spectacle, returned as witness.

Rios approaches. He places his BADGE next to the photos. Authority set down as accountability.

He opens the LEDGER a little farther. New ink in Rios' hand — MARCUS HARJO. ELI BLACKDEER. THE TRUCKER'S NAME. Older names above them. No blank spaces left.

A nod passes between him and Mary. Heavy. Forged.

Two LOCAL TEENS stand near the back. One holds up a PHONE:

ON SCREEN, a MUTED CLIP of RIOS at a TOWN HALL MIC, the ledger on a podium in front of him, faces behind him. The teen watches a beat, pockets the phone, turns back to the candles.

Wind brushes through the pines. The spiral of candles trembles, stays lit.

Silence wraps the clearing.

An old PORTABLE SPEAKER crackles to life. A HO-CHUNK SONG OF REMEMBRANCE — an old recording Mary chose — drifts out, low and steady. Words in Ho-Chunk, untranslated, carried by the trees. (NOTE: Specific Song Choice to be developed in consultation with Ho-Chunk representatives.)

Kai keeps sketching, softer now. Lina rests her head against his shoulder.

Rowan stands beside Ruth, close enough to steady her if she sways. She does not.

Ezra fingers the mark on his shoulder, now only a pale scar. He stays in the circle.

Rios steps back beside the elders, no longer apart.

Mary closes her eyes, tears catching in the lines of her face. Neeka's hand finds hers.

LUTHER (V.O.)
What we bury never stays gone.
(beat)
Memory can hold it different.

Eyes close. Heads bow. Some people cry openly. Some stand dry-eyed, knuckles white, listening.

The camera lingers on faces in the circle — Ho-Chunk families, town kids, elders, Rios, Mary, Neeka, Ruth, Kai, Lina, Rowan, Ezra — all threaded into the same moment.

Flame. Breath. Smoke. Memory.

FADE TO BLACK.

THE END.